

WEEK 10 · WORK

CLASS 2
Work and Play

READING 1

“Chapter 3: Children’s Work and Play” in *Growing Up Global* – Katz

Growing Up Global: Economic Restructuring and Children's Everyday Lives | Katz

Week 10, Class 2

Chapter 3: Children's Work and Play — pp. 59–108

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3. Children's Work and Play

It's mid-July and everybody is weeding. Tenants, their sons, nephews, brothers, and hired hands are immersed in the first of four weeding. Ismail has been assisting his maternal uncle Said in their groundnut fields for the last couple of weeks. On one of these mornings he met up with his uncle at his grandparents' compound just before seven o'clock and they went together to his tenancy, just near the major canal. Getting to the fields around seven-thirty, Ismail and his young uncle set to work up and down the rows. They used the short-handled hoe (*kedunka*) mandated by the project administration to hack out the weeds. These hoes were made by local carpenters, who also made shorter handled tools for children's use. Ismail's hoe was one of these. Said was more skilled and speedy than Ismail, but Ismail worked hard and well, modeling his actions upon those of his uncle. They occasionally stopped to clean the clayey soil from the blades of their hoes, using a piece of scrap metal that Said had picked up on the way out. Weeding along the last planted row near the feeder canal, Ismail did not recognize some recently sprouted *onkolib* (sweet sorghum, *Sorghum spp. gramineae*) until his uncle stopped him from weeding it. Ismail said that he thought it was *adar*, a tall grass in the same family (*Sorghum vergatum*) that was considered a weed in the fields, although it was a source of fodder. In general Ismail was good at discerning cultivated from unwanted plants and could recognize most of the horticultural things planted along the edges of the field, including lentils, haricot beans, and corn. Now he recognized onkolib.

After weeding about half an acre, they found the rest of the ground too wet to continue and left it for another day. Moving to a section that had already been weeded, they neatened a part of it by clearing the few remaining weeds. By about eight-thirty

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they were ready to return home, but Ismail's mother had requested that he bring back some *mulayta* (*Picridium trigitanum* Desf.), a green that grew profusely along the canals. People in Howa relished the bitter green—eaten fresh—and often asked their children to gather some when they went to the fields. Ismail picked greens for about twenty minutes, filling a bag the size of a pillow that he had tied around him as he picked. He gave two-thirds of the *mulayta* to his grandparents and brought the rest home.

Environmental knowledge is practical knowledge. In Howa it included knowledge of the local terrain, available resources, land-use practices, and environmental processes fundamental to production and reproduction. Like all knowledge it was learned in a community of practice (Lave and Wenger 1991). Adults and teenagers shared this knowledge with children through a variety of means—conscious and not—starting in early childhood. Through direct oral instruction, stories, songs, riddles, demonstration, apprenticeship, guided practice, and shared activities, adults ensured that their rich and evolving store of knowledge about the environment was passed on as a routine part of everyday life. Children also acquired environmental knowledge in the course of their autonomous activities with peers and older children. Their routine activities and everyday interactions—both work and play—offered opportunities to acquire, try out, use, master, reimagine, and alter environmental knowledge. Each of these material social practices was important for the continuation of village life and helped shape the children's impending adulthoods.

Work and play were key and critical means through which children reproduced themselves and the social and economic life of their village. Play and work were intertwined in the time-space of children's everyday lives in Howa with deep resonances between the two. An element of play was almost fused with the work of children—they worked at play and played at work—temporally, metaphorically, and imaginatively. They worked while they played and played while they worked, they worked around their play and they played in the interstices of their work, they participated in tasks that were playful and play that was “workful,” and they engaged in play activities whose focus was work.

The unities that bound work and play in the children's everyday lives frayed under the impress of the changes brought about by the agricultural project and its attendant social relations. One of the obvious reasons for this unraveling was the increase in children's work time resulting from the intensified cultivation requirements of the project, the decreased availability of wood and the deterioration of nearby pasture areas, and the heightened monetization of the local economy. Still, the ties that joined work and play in Howa were numerous and durable, in part because even as children worked more, it was hard to drain the play out of them. Nevertheless, some of the fine weave between certain work and play practices was worn thin by the uncertainties for the future posed by the project. Yet this is precisely why the children's work and play activities and their intertwinings were of so much interest to me. If in their work and play children encountered, made sense of, and tried to prepare themselves for the

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world, they also encountered and engaged the inchoateness of the ways that new and old social relations and cultural forms and practices clashed in that world. Their playful work and workful play were not only ways of making sense of and negotiating these shifting conditions, but they offered glimpses of creative possibilities that were new and different.

In this chapter, I examine the unfolding of the children's work and play as material social practices, looking at their meanings for both the village and the children themselves and suggesting how these activities and the relations between them were changed in the encounter with the new political ecologies of everyday life in Howa. The discussion describes how play and work and their relationships were altered in the political-economic transformation that was taking place in Howa and offers them up as a way to imagine and even produce something different of it.

Work and Play in Howa

It's just after six o'clock on a June morning and Merwan is rounding up his flock, making shepherd sounds (a series of clicks, "sshts," and high-pitched "ayes" that the animals respond to) and using his long stick to prod and hit the animals into motion. His uncle helps him get the animals out of their houseyard and moving toward "the East" (an open forest savannah to the east of the still-dry river). Within minutes Merwan is heading back carrying two lambs that were to stay behind. He quickly returns to his flock of about sixty small animals, mostly sheep, and energetically keeps them moving, making lots of shepherd sounds and scampering around them. He spots a friend on the horizon and waits at the riverbank for him and a couple of other boys to catch up so they can hang out together while their animals graze. The flocks get mingled as the boys work together—making noises and hitting the animals—to get them to descend the steep bank. As the animals graze along the riverbed the boys do acrobatics in its soft sandy bottom. . . .

After making themselves a breakfast of fresh milk and porridge brought from home, the boys move the animals up the steep eastern bank and over to a maya (depression) about a ten-minutes' walk away. Compared to Saddiq and his friends, these herd-boys seem relaxed about getting the animals to the maya, and don't seem too worried about whether any of them might have wandered off or been left behind. As they reach the slightly more vegetated maya, the boys immediately begin searching for camel dung so they can play *mala*, a game similar to jacks that uses camel dung as the playing pieces. Each boy finds his twenty pieces and they begin to play in the shade of an acacia as the animals graze around them. The animals eat their way about one hundred meters to the east and every once in a while one of the boys casts an eye toward them. Their *mala* is spirited, full of pinching cheeks and hitting vanquished opponents, cheering at one's own successes, and chomping on fingers in a performance of nervousness after dropping playing pieces. Amid the good-natured arguing about various moves, I notice Merwan cheating—he distracts one of his friends while simultaneously slipping the

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boy's pieces into his own pile. The move is unnoticed and the boys continue to play for about forty-five minutes, during which time the animals drift back to the river. One boy is delegated to go after them, and with a shower of shepherd noises and the occasional use of his whip, he rounds up all of the animals and leads them back to the maya. Not long after, the boys themselves head off to play again in the sandy river bottom, leaving the animals to continue grazing in the depression.

Work, Play, and Environmental Knowledge

In their work and play, ten-year-old children learned, integrated, mastered, and used many of the environmental skills and much of the knowledge fundamental to the agriculture, animal husbandry, forestry, and resource use that dominated the economic life of Howa. The range of activities in which they engaged or manipulated the physical environment was extremely broad and varied. Many of these tasks were considered children's jobs, and by ten most children exhibited mastery or near mastery of the knowledge and skills required to carry them out. These tasks included herding, drawing water, gathering fuelwood, and collecting certain wild foods.

In other activities children assisted adults. In these, children may have mastered one part of a complex process, and as they carried it out learned other aspects of the task as a whole. Such was the case with farming. Children's labor was essential to most agricultural chores, but at ten they had not yet mastered the interrelationship and sequencing of the complex processes of agricultural production, even as they learned discrete aspects of these processes in the course of their everyday tasks. In agriculture, as with most other environmental activities, children learned by doing, watching, and receiving something like on-the-job training from their elders, siblings, or peers. Some skills, like the specialized use of certain local resources, were taught to children more formally by adults.

Most environmental knowledge was shared less formally, however, as part of the give-and-take of everyday life. As children played, worked, and explored the village and its surroundings, they often asked peers or elders to explain or identify objects or processes they were curious about. For their part, adults often imparted information about the environment casually or as it was appropriate, pointing out which trees to cut, guiding a child's hand as she reconstructed a shallow well in the riverbed, or instructing a young boy on ways to trap and kill birds. Adults and older kids were also careful to correct children's mistakes in identifying, understanding, and using local resources as these instances arose, just as Ismail's uncle did when he mistook the sweet sorghum for a weed (see, for example, Fortes 1970; Raum 1940; Middleton 1970; Modiano 1973; Ruddle and Chesterfield 1977; Porter 1996). Idle hours around the houseyard were sometimes spent puzzling through riddles (*hajwa*) or reciting rhymes that often as not conveyed environmental information (see Hurriez and Bell 1975).

It was late April and the dense and steamy heat of *sayf* (summer) was upon us. Finally grasping what it was about "mad dogs and Englishmen," I sat out the midday

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sun in the shaded *rakuba* (grass veranda) of Ismail's family. As I sunk into a seat on one of several rope beds arrayed around the "veranda," Ismail told me that he'd seen a *simbriya* (Abdim's Stork, *Ciconia abdimi*) that morning. That means it will rain soon, he let us know, because *simbriya* come during *kherif*, the rainy season. With the mix of sweetness, excitement, and wisdom that was his trademark, he launched into a nursery rhyme that marks the stork's role as a harbinger:

Al Simbriya Um Guddoum
 Aysh Aboui Bigoom
 Mitaya Bitgoom Bakir
 Ma' al Asakir

The Abdim's stork with its long bill
 My father's sorghum sprouts
 It will grow tomorrow
 With the dawn [literally, "With the army"]

This released a barrage of riddles and rhymes. Ismail told some to his relatives, while others were inflicted upon him. The next also involved a bird, the white stork (*Ciconia ciconia*), which he called *Um al jeday*, though elsewhere in Sudan they are referred to as *Ab al Jebar*, a reference to their enormous size. "Um al Jeday," Ismail sang out, "Hannini e dai, Hannini kour ai!" (hennaed hands, hennaed feet). Our talk wandered back to the *simbriya* and I asked what they ate. His great-aunt immediately answered sorghum, prompting Ismail to ask, "Don't they eat grass too?" And she assured him that they did. The conversation moved on to vultures and Ismail provided a vivid—even lurid—description of carrion. Habiba, his younger cousin, who loved all things gory, made sure to tell us how the vultures ate the eyes of their quarry. This prompted yet another bird-identifying rhyme, about a carrion-eating bird, "Hourab Hourab, Kubba addum, Gal Hurrum" (Hourab, Hourab, spills blood, swears its might). Jumping along, Ismail got on the subject of *hidaya* (*Elanus caeruleus*, black shouldered kites), letting me know that they eat chicks. The assembled contributed a few more riddles about animals and everyday life, and Ismail concluded with one about *kakool*, the gum that oozed from acacias in places where the bark was disturbed: "If you take one today / another will grow tomorrow." He had learned this and some of the other riddles from his herdboy cousin, Saddiq. Children and others out in the brush often pulled wads of *kakool* off acacias to chew. With little taste but a lot of texture, *kakool* is similar to gum arabic, which comes from *Acacia senegal*, but it has no economic value.

Everyone enjoyed exchanging *hajwa*, though they were considered largely the province of grandmothers. They were so much a part of cultural learning in Sudan that radio and television programs for children had adopted the form, and—so people in Howa told me—were gradually putting grandmothers out of business. Play was another means through which children acquired, internalized, and integrated environmental knowledge. It offered them a way to practice their environmental skills,

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while providing an arena in which they could “romance” about what they were learning, imagine alternate outcomes, and even make up aspects they vaguely understood or had yet to learn.

The following examination of the key environmental activities of children in Howa weaves together descriptions of the practices themselves, discussions of the variety of connections between work and play in the children's lives, and analyses of how these activities were connected to the larger political economy and ecology within which they occurred. As the examples woven through this discussion demonstrate, the interrelationship and balance among children's work, play, and learning, and the back and forth between the adults' and children's practices were striking.

Time-Economics of Children's Work

The porous border between commodity and subsistence production in Howa had an interesting effect on children's participation in various work activities. In the initial year of this project, I documented the full range of activities—work and play—of a group of seventeen ten-year-old children. My analysis of their work revealed that socioeconomic factors, such as parental occupation and household socioeconomic status, influenced children's participation in work undertaken to produce income or to further household capital accumulation, such as agriculture, animal husbandry, and charcoal production; on the other hand, individual demographic characteristics, such as gender or birth-order position, were more influential for their participation in tasks of household maintenance and reproduction, including the procurement of water, fuel, and noncultivated foods for household consumption. Because reproductive work took place in every household regardless of economic status, these daily tasks drew heavily on the labor of children across the board, whether from poor or relatively well-off households. Other forms of work, by contrast, required particular assets, such as animals or a tenancy. The availability of such assets affected whether or not children worked, and resulted in my somewhat counterintuitive finding that children in wealthier households often worked longer hours and at more tasks than children in poorer ones.

While this distinction was true overall, children's work activities were, of course, influenced by a number of factors whose relative importance varied largely according to the task. Neither the variables nor the tasks themselves were mutually exclusive. It goes without saying, for instance, that a family must have animals to require a child to work as a shepherd, but in Howa this socioeconomic factor intersected with the gendering of herding as exclusively a boys' task. Once a boy was a herder, however, the constancy of his work precluded him from assisting with most other household chores. In other words, children's customary tasks exerted their own influence upon their participation in other activities. These distinctions are often missed in analyses of children's work, which tend to look at particular demographic or socioeconomic variables and assess their impact on work participation, rather than examining the interweave

between tasks, household economics, and the particular characteristics of the children. The significance of the analytic distinction between work that was reproductive and work that was undertaken for exchange or in relation to capital accumulation and how that distinction affected children's responsibilities and use of time was striking. Also striking were the intrahousehold effects of gender, age, birth-order position, and customary responsibilities.

In a related vein, as was noted above, the children of wealthier households tended to be more encumbered than others. Because of the diversification of the household economy, children from wealthier households tended to work more hours than those less well off, mostly because herding and, to a lesser extent, farming were so time consuming. Although children from the poorest families were often forced by circumstances to work at many tasks, their households lacked the resources that would have employed them over long hours. Instead they worked at a range of subsistence and income-generating activities that did not depend on household assets, such as land and livestock. Thus, while children from poorer households in Howa tended to work at a greater array of activities, those in wealthier households tended to work longer hours. But more than this, it appeared that the economic diversification that characterized wealthier households led them to employ their children more intensively than others did in the village. There was also a tendency among these families to groom their children—more accurately, their sons—to tend particular areas of the family's operations. Thus one son might take care of the animals and learn the ins and outs of animal husbandry, another might specialize in agriculture, a third might work in the family store or assist on their truck and so learn to be a merchant, while yet another would be formally educated through secondary school and beyond, if possible.

In his work on children's labor in Char Gopalpur, Bangladesh, Mead Cain (1977, 219) also found that the children of better-off families tended to work at different activities than their peers from poorer households. In Char Gopalpur, as in Howa, boys from richer households were more likely to work at tasks such as herding and crop production, while those from poorer households were more likely to work at fishing or wage labor. Cain found, as did I, that children from wealthier households also worked at an earlier age than those from poorer households on tasks that required assets, such as agriculture and animal husbandry. These tasks were inaccessible to poorer children except through wage labor, the opportunities for which were limited for very young children. In Howa, it was even the case that young children who worked as paid field hands were more likely than not to be from tenant households. Although access to land was through the agricultural project, and tenancies were not neatly correlated with wealth, it seemed that a familiarity with the tasks developed from working in the tenancies of their households and chance encounters with other tenants while out in the fields made these children more likely than others to pick up agricultural work at an early age.

Finally, my work revealed an interesting relationship between school attendance and work. While school attendance did not preclude children's participation in most

of the environmental work practices of their community, it certainly structured their time differently and made extra-household demands on them. Although I found extremely low rates of school enrollment in Howa (42 percent among boys between seven and twelve; 4 percent among girls of the same age), I also found low rates of absenteeism. Once a family made a commitment to send their child to school, they appeared to respect the restrictions that attendance made on him or her, and did not interfere by demanding that the child work during school times. Children who were students participated in all the agricultural tasks that took place during the three-month school holiday, which coincided with the rainy season, but they participated much less frequently in the tasks of clearing and harvesting because these took place during term. Even though harvest work was particularly labor-demanding, parents did not pull their children from school to participate. Harvest work was usually done by women and girls, however, and girls' school enrollment was so small that its effects on participation in this activity were relatively negligible. Nevertheless, in later periods of my study I learned that one of the reasons girls left school was to participate in cotton picking, which was seasonally lucrative. Others suggest an opposite trend. David Landy (1959) and Marta Tienda (1979), working in Puerto Rico and Peru, respectively, found much higher levels of school enrollment than I did (80 percent in rural Puerto Rico and 77 percent in rural Peru), but more frequent absenteeism when children were needed for labor-intensive agricultural or other tasks.

In Howa, on the other hand, where school enrollment was only 24 percent overall, households made every attempt to manage without the assistance of school children, even during the busiest periods. However, when children's labor was important across a range of tasks, or for an essential year-round activity such as herding, they either were never enrolled or left school before completion. This was often the case in Howa. Among the seventeen children working with me, eleven were not enrolled in school. Of these, the work of seven was essential to their households. The low levels of school enrollment in Howa were a clear reflection of the importance of children's labor to their households.

Talal, for instance, was one of the hardest working children I knew. He worked more than four hours a day all year long, participating significantly in animal husbandry, procuring water and fuel, assisting in the fields, and gathering wild foods. His labor contributions to agriculture and fetching water were particularly critical. Both activities were necessary not only to his household's reproduction, but to its economic well-being. When I first met Talal at the beginning of 1981 he was a student in the third grade. His work time was governed largely by the school schedule, which allowed time each afternoon and on Fridays to fetch water or gather fuelwood for household consumption. During the summer holidays he participated in the agricultural tasks of planting and weeding, but because of school, not in the bulk of clearing and harvest activities. Talal was the oldest child in his family, and at ten he was mature and strong enough to help significantly with a range of tasks, either working independently or alongside his father. By early 1981 the need for his labor, as well as

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the money he was able to earn daily from selling water (the equivalent of approximately US\$1.00), outweighed for his parents the advantage of keeping Talal in school. After the school break in April he did not return to school. At first he and his family denied that this situation was permanent and indicated that he would resume after the summer holidays that ran from June through September. I came to realize that the family was humoring me, if not themselves. Given their precarious economic existence and Talal's consistent hard work across a range of tasks, school had become an unaffordable luxury for them.

Unities of Work and Play

Talal's withdrawal from school should not be scripted as entrapment in a grim life of constant toil, however. Work and play remained tightly bound in many ways in the children's lives, and Talal was no exception. One of his myriad projects, for instance, involved the construction of a small kitchen for his mother. The many intrinsic pleasures of the activities involved were as obvious as their purposiveness: Talal and his friends energetically demolished a nearby crumbling mud house and carted back the dirt to build the kitchen, went to the woods to find just the right saplings for its door, and built and fussed over the finishing touches to the (unrequested) simple structure. This was typical. Children's work time was often imbued with playfulness, while their play was often goal directed and worklike—all of which raise profound questions about the nature of work and play in children's lives in Howa and beyond.

The ties between work and play were multiple and varied. Work and play were bound temporally; activities associated with each were simultaneous, overlapping, or punctuated by one another. Much work was playful, especially that which took the children on journeys outside the village, and a lot of play activities were "workful," such as Talal's kitchen project or other boys' bird-snaring. Still other forms of play—such as the endless dramatic games of "fields"—rehearsed work activities that the children engaged in at other times, while some play involved toying with likely future work activities, such as the girls' games of "house." These unities—and the threats against them—are addressed in the discussions of the children's activities, below. The activities, which encompass the material social practices of animal husbandry, fetching water, procuring fuelwood, agriculture, and collecting wild food and other resources from the surrounding environment, cover almost all of the most important ways children in Howa spent their time outside of school. However, my focus on activities that were particularly environmental downplays household domestic labor, in which children's role was often substantial. Activities such as child care, cooking, cleaning, running errands, and other household chores absorbed a substantial amount of children's time. These activities dot the periphery of the descriptions that follow, but their importance—both in consuming children's time and in the significance of children's contribution to their getting done—was anything but peripheral.

Herding

Herding was one of the principal activities of children. All of the shepherds in Howa were boys. They ranged in age from about ten to eighteen, but a few continued to herd until their early twenties. Not only was this crucial aspect of animal husbandry solely a young person's task, but going out every day of the year from dawn until dusk inevitably separated herdboys from all others. Once a boy became a shepherd (as early as eight, but more commonly around ten), care of the family's livestock away from the houseyard was solely his responsibility. The task was not passed down successively among brothers and the responsibility was shared with them only because of illness, exhaustion, or extreme heat during the hottest part of the year, when staying out in the sun all day could be dangerous even for the young and accustomed. Because it was a daily task, engaged in by a stable group of boys who spent long hours together everyday over several years, herding was understandably a cliquish arena in which work and play were often simultaneous and overlapping.

Three of the ten boys with whom I worked were shepherds. A fourth, Rashid, herded his family's ten animals on his days off from school. Otherwise, they were grazed by a paid herdboys. Two others took care of their family's donkeys; one watered the donkey used by his father, and the other, Talal, watered, fed, and cleaned the corral of the donkey that he used for collecting wood, fetching water and other activities. When families had small numbers of animals, children often led them to pasture and left them to graze on their own. While girls were not shepherds in Howa, many led their families' animals to and from these nearby grazing areas. Two of the seven girls with whom I worked were frequently responsible for this task. In Howa, almost all milking was done by women, and I rarely saw children milk except when they wanted a drink while out with the flocks.

Shepherds exhibited an extraordinary level of care and responsibility in their work. They were also responsible for cleaning the animals and their quarters, ensuring the safety of their charges, and preventing their families' flocks from roaming, which some shepherds did with less vigilance than others. In the course of their work, herdboys developed and used a finely detailed knowledge of local microenvironments and vegetation to ensure adequate and appropriate grazing for their animals each season. In the course of an interview with Saddiq, for instance, I sketched a map laying out about forty discrete grazing areas that he identified within a four-kilometer radius of the village. His intricate geographical knowledge was typical of herdboys in Howa. With some guidance from their fathers, these boys were able to manage the diverse grazing areas around Howa to maximize limited and declining pasture lands. In daily exchanges the boys told their parents which areas were wet, overgrazed, vegetated, or otherwise, and then negotiated the day's grazing to optimize the resources of the wet and dry seasons and ensure that the animals had access to vegetation with various properties. Of course they might change the plans en route for any number of reasons, including news of flooding, friends' plans, exhaustion, or whimsy. Most accounted for their trajectories each evening, when they were often grilled about whether the animals were watered and what they had grazed upon.

When I was out grazing with Merwan one day in late September—just about the most verdant time of the year—he identified (at my behest) thirty-five distinct plants, mostly grasses—over the course of a two-hour ramble, and informed me about each plant's properties as fodder or as risks to the animals. The variation was splendid and Merwan knew a lot of the plants. On a couple of occasions he said he didn't know the name of something and a couple of other times he identified a plant incorrectly. On each of these four occasions other shepherds nearby, usually older, provided the correct information.

We sat in the shade of a tree for a while as I scribbled madly, trying to get down all he'd said, but after a while Merwan said that the animals had roamed off and we had to go round them up. In pursuit of the flock, we meandered through the greenery, joining up with others and then parting ways just as casually. Eventually we made our way to a *maya* (depression) which was by now quite full—knee- to waist-high water filled the expanse so that it looked like a shimmering pond. Grasses and other greens were growing in it along with many—at present very lush—trees. Birds were abundant near the water, and the kids identified about a dozen of them. When they spotted the bird *Ab Gambour*, one of them called out, “Ab gambour, hella jour!!” Ab gambour, it turned out, was not just the name of a bird, but also the nickname of one of the boys, and revealing this let loose an incredible discussion of nicknames. Each boy had at least one and sometimes several nicknames known to their extended group of friends—all herdboys. The names were funny, derivative, and affectionate; defining an in-group and excluding all others. In learning them, I felt that much more in the club. They, in turn, were completely amused at my writing down the names—about thirty in all—and got me to read them out loud at least six times throughout the day.

Though herdboys might leave home each day with a plan, their movements were often influenced by social and other interests. Apart from serendipitous encounters with other herdboys and children out collecting wood or wild foods, or working in the fields, shepherds often traveled together from the start of the day or arranged to meet and play during their long days. Particular sites such as the riverbed, waterlogged depressions (*maya*), and the canal were favored for these encounters. During the heat of the day, the boys often headed for the shade of the few remaining large trees dotting the open land surrounding the village. In these favored spots herdboys played while they worked. Not only was the fusion between work and play marked in their daily routines, but it was often difficult to distinguish what was play and what was work.

Later that same day with Merwan and his friends we came to a *maya* full of *suteb*, the potato-like root of a local variety of water lily. *Suteb* are a shepherd delicacy, if for no other reason than that almost nobody else can get to them, and they were growing thickly in the middle of this particular pool. No sooner had we gotten there but the boys were stripping down to their shorts and racing into the water. They darted for the middle and began ducking down to yank the *suteb* from the mud. There were

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about six or seven boys out there and they stayed out for about a half hour, horsing around as they filled the aprons of their shorts or shirts with the roots. In the interim, a slightly older shepherd arrived and one by one drove his sheep into the water to bathe them. After Merwan returned from his dunking expedition he helped the older boy in immersing and scrubbing each sheep. Eventually he returned to the shore with about a dozen suteb tucked into his pants waist. Other kids had similar yields. Merwan immediately rinsed one and ate it raw, but suggested I wait for the real delicacy—boiled or roasted. One boy had matches and kindled a fire, another filled an enamel bowl with water. As the roots cooked, Merwan changed back into his short caftan and rinsed out his wet clothes, all the while checking on the whereabouts of his flock.

The frolics, shared meals, songs, riddles, stories, word games (which included making up cascades of names for one another), bird watching, hunting, swimming, wrestling, and more organized action games were routine parts of a shepherd's day. These activities overlapped and were often continuous with the work of herding. While the animals wandered—sometimes too far—the boys played circle games, made themselves into “trains” running through the sandy riverbed, swam, sang songs, or gathered seasonal foods to eat. The environmental content of some these activities, such as bird watching or food gathering, the lyrics to songs, and the content of some riddles and tales were important for acquiring or reinforcing environmental knowledge. But more than that, the easy overlap between work and play helped the boys to pass the long hot days with a minimum of tedium and with obvious pleasure.

The cooperativeness and camaraderie among the shepherds were impressive, even in a village where both of these qualities were instilled in children from an early age. These characteristics were also crucial to their work. The herdboys' affinities were forged in the long days spent together, in the shared responsibility for their families' wealth, in their adventures discovering new grazing areas and daring the guards of the irrigation project, and in the special things, experiences, and information shared only among shepherds. These exchanges appeared to give herdboys the sense that they were different from other children. Their sense of uniqueness and solidarity was reinforced by their cultural practices, including, for instance, shared beliefs, lore, and values, and the encoding of much of their knowledge in a specialized language that included nicknames known only to themselves. As is often the case with youth “gangs” or cliques, these markers of self-definition were used smugly if not derisively against outliers, especially students, who were often scripted as knowing nothing.

Merwan and I were sitting under a tree, trying to stay cool in the middle of June while the animals grazed on the eastern side of the Dinder, when a couple of herdboys approached. “They're good kids,” he told me, taking pleasure in their approach. “All shepherds are good kids,” he went on. I wondered about other kids. “Nah,” he said with obvious disdain and a little bit of chauvinism, “students are no good.”

The self-conscious reproduction of herdboy culture was integral to their work. This culture sustained the boys daily and over the years, but within it there was great

autonomy. The boys who herded in Howa, almost to a one, were independent, inventive, and self-confident. Those who were not, such as Mohamed, another of the herdboys who worked with me, were neither accepted in the group nor as successful at their work as those who were. The lack of camaraderie could have tragic consequences. Mohamed, who was a solitary shepherd and a bit of a loner, fell into the swift currents of the Dinder River in flood and drowned because he could neither swim nor pull himself up on the shore. While the Dinder can be quite strong, and the presence of fellow herdboys would not have guaranteed survival, it is most likely that had other boys been around, they would have managed to save Mohamed if only by screaming and running for help.

The comprehensive social network and strong social bonds among shepherds were important, then, because they facilitated the work of animal husbandry and eased the psychic and physical burdens on individual herdboys. Herdboys who, for whatever reason were outside of these social networks, missed out on the play and camaraderie that made the long hours pass more pleasantly. Mohamed, who generally spent his days herding alone, tended to return home in the afternoon. As a result his family had to hire a herdboy to keep the animals out the rest of the day. Likewise, Rashid, who took his household's small flock out on school holidays, worked pretty much alone and was not enamored with the tedious prospect of herding all day. Isolation also limited the lone shepherds' access to the information shared easily within the moving clusters of herdboys concerning the best grazing sites or problems in certain areas, and decreased the likelihood they would receive warnings about guards in areas off-limits to livestock.

The centrality of children's role in animal husbandry did not mean that they determined any of its economic aspects. Here, their fathers were firmly in control. Livestock was an adult investment, and usually represented the bulk of family wealth, however great or small. The seriousness of the investment was seen in the deep and constant concern of animal owners that their animals were well-fed and watered, safe from physical harm, prevented from grazing on potentially injurious fodder, and out of the way of both police and thieves. Parents carefully selected which of their sons would be the family herdboy. Shepherds were supervised closely through intensive questioning at the end of each day as to where the animals grazed, what they grazed upon, and whether any problems were encountered.

Adults were perennially concerned that their sons would be distracted playing and let the animals wander off, graze on harmful vegetation, or get caught in project lands and end up being impounded and incurring fines. Though the shepherds did indeed get absorbed in play, they almost never let the animals slip away entirely. The punishment was such that they were not likely to let it happen too often. On one occasion Saddiq, a scrupulously responsible herdboy, was hit several times when he arrived home at the end of a long day because his father had learned (from Saddiq's older and far less responsible twelve-year-old brother) that one of their animals had been impounded. Despite his general responsibility, Saddiq's costly error was not taken lightly. In fact his father was so steamed that he waited at the edge of the village to have at him the

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moment he returned. Of course, like many parent-child tiffs, there was a bit of cognitive dissonance at work. In interviews and casual conversations with me, many men recounted their own playful transgressions as herdboys in the same breath that they admonished their sons for doing the same. Such are the interweavings of work and play in time, space, and memory.

Fetching Water

Late afternoon and the girls as usual are playing dolls in the shade of a wall enclosing the houseyard. The homemade grass dolls have cooked, cleaned, and entertained guests. Now Suad is maneuvering her doll to go to the well. She carries her to a nearby *zir* (large clay water jug), fills a small cup of water, and carries the doll back to the makeshift dwelling the girls have crafted against the wall, all the while balancing the cup of water over the doll's head.

No matter what else was going on, hauling water was an integral part of every day's activities. Fetching water was another arena of work where children's contributions were pivotal. In most areas of Africa, and indeed in many parts of Sudan, women have primary responsibility for providing both fuel and water. But in this part of Islamic Sudan, women in their prime childbearing years (between approximately fifteen and thirty-two) were discouraged from working outside their household compounds during the day because it was not considered proper for them to be seen in public.¹ It is logical, then, that in Howa and probably in many other areas where Islam predominates, children have greater responsibility for providing the means of existence, such as water and fuel, than they do in areas where women are able to carry out these tasks. What I found in Howa dovetails with Enid Schildkrout's (1981) conclusion that it was the labor of children that enabled *purdah*, the seclusion of women, to persist in Islamic urban Nigeria.² Through the course of a year, children in Howa made literally thousands of trips to get water from the village well, the river or its dry bed, and the irrigation canal. Although both women and men in Howa fetched water routinely, children were the predominant figures at each water source.

Children began drawing water for their households when they were as young as seven, making repeated trips to the well or river—often in the tow of older siblings—and carrying small buckets or plastic containers, as their size allowed. My findings suggest that children and adolescents of both sexes were responsible for drawing 80 percent of the water consumed each day in village households. Thirteen of the seventeen children with whom I worked fetched water for their households and extended families at least some of the time. Five of these children were responsible for fetching all or most of the water used in their households. One child, Talal, sold water regularly in the village and Miriam sometimes did. She was especially active during the agricultural season, when demand was higher because people spent so much time in the fields. The figures derived from the children working with me were representative of the village as

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a whole, where more than 75 percent of all ten-year-olds drew water for their households and about 6 percent of the ten-year-olds sold water regularly.

Gender and birth order exerted a strong influence on participation in these tasks. Girls were more important for providing household water than boys, and oldest children in a household, especially girls, tended to take on the task earlier and keep it longer than younger siblings. Among the children with whom I worked, four of the five who fetched most or all of the water for their households were girls. The sole boy was, significantly, the oldest child in his family. Three of the four girls who fetched most of the water in their households were, likewise, the oldest girls in their households. The fourth had an older sister close in age with whom she shared most tasks, including drawing water. The sisters as often as not switched off between fetching water and caring for their baby brother. On the other side, all four of those who never fetched water were boys with older sisters who were largely responsible for the task. Similarly, in those households where the child who worked with me fetched water only some of the time, it was an older sister who took care of most of the rest.

The well is closed again so I wander down to the riverbed. It's a hive of activity—a young teenage boy had just collected a sack of riverbed sand to use for plastering a house and is hoisting it onto his donkey when it spills out. As he refills the sack, five teenage girls pass by on their way back from “the East” with huge bundles of wood on their heads. Two women follow with equally hefty loads, theirs topped with axes. They are accompanied by five little children; the four girls, who are about five years old, have small bundles of twigs on their heads while the boy—who looks about four—carries a small bowl of twigs on his head. Two seven- or eight-year-old boys pass carrying axes and large bundles of wood on their backs. On the steep western bank the wood gatherers merge with people getting water. It being close to sunset, there is a steady stream of people coming up from the river with water. A man on a donkey, a seven-year-old boy with a two-gallon container, two women with five-gallon containers on their heads, and four young girls—about eight years old—carrying small buckets on their heads are steadily climbing up the slope. I count thirty-two people still in the riverbed, twenty-five of whom are women or girls. Among them are two women doing their laundry in the stagnant water near the banks where animals drink and people paddle about, cooling off and cleaning their feet. Near the shallow wells in the center, it is noisy as people draw water and wait their turns at the jemmam. People splash and play with the water, taking pleasure in the cool wetness and the soft river bottom sand. As the sun sets, more people arrive, taking advantage of the relative cool to get one last bit of water for the evening and early morning.

The river was frequently abuzz, while the wells—scenes of bedlam during their brief opening hours—were all too often silent. Shuttered for any number of reasons, the two diesel-pumped artesian wells (one longstanding and the second completed toward the end of 1981) were luckily backed up by three other sources: jemmam or shallow wells dug in the subsurface of the ephemeral river that bordered the village, the

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Dinder itself when in flow during the rainy season, and the major canal of the agricultural project, which separated the village from the fields.

Both wells were within village bounds not much further than half a kilometer from any houseyard. The water was not only the cleanest of all the available sources, but also required the least labor time for its procurement. During my stay in Howa, however, the second well was under construction and the original well did not operate an average of one in four days, either because of mechanical breakdown or because it lacked spare parts, diesel fuel, or a well operator, who, it turned out, had a wife in another village. When the well was closed, most households returned to Howa's original source of water—the Dinder River, an ephemeral stream alongside the village. Some turned to the newest and least sanitary source of water—the major canal of the irrigation project. For most, the choice of alternative water source when the well was closed was determined by proximity and the labor requirements of drawing water from it, rather than the quality of the water.³ These decisions were often made by children.

Talal was at the canal around eight in the morning getting water for his family when he was commissioned to get water for another household. But before he did he had to deliver his own family's water, where unexpectedly he got enmeshed in totaling the groundnuts being shelled by a bunch of kids working in front of his family's house. He registered each child's name and total so that his father could later pay them for their piece work. Talal eventually remembered to get water for the other household, but almost four hours had elapsed since the request. By then the well was open, but since the family who had requested the water lived on the edge of town close to the canal, Talal opted to get canal water because it was much less time consuming. He could draw the water in minutes and deliver it much more quickly from that end of town. He saddled up his donkey, topping it with a cross pole holding two large containers—one tin, the other plastic, each holding about five gallons—and headed to the canal with his brother riding on back. Dismounting quickly, Talal waded in up to his thighs to fill the plastic jug. The can had sprung a leak, and Talal deliberately patched the hole with some mud before wading back in with it. After filling the repaired can he struggled to get the pair balanced across the patient donkey's back. He hooked the rope to the first can, went round to the other side of the donkey and had to use all his weight—his two feet pressed against the donkey's side as he yanked on the pole, neck muscles visibly straining—to cantilever it up and bring the cross pole down to the other jug. After all that struggle he was surprised to discover that his prospective customers had—of all things in four hours—already gotten water. Undaunted, if slightly disappointed, Talal rode to the bakery to see if they were interested, but it being canal water, they were not. He rode off to hawk the water in the village, confident that someone would buy it, even though it was murky canal water. Indeed, in all my time in Howa I never saw anyone—not the social workers, the teachers, or the health practitioner—refuse canal water when alternatives were unavailable. Though everyone probably thought I was somewhat hysterical on this question, I preferred the prospect of slowly dying of thirst.

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Prior to the construction of Howa's first well in the mid-1960s, the Dinder was the sole source of water. During that time, as later when the well was closed, people fetched water from the river in flow during the rainy months from July through October. This water was silty but "clean" because of the swiftness of the river in flood. But this swiftness made the water hazardous to procure, and young children were not sent to negotiate the steep riverbanks. As the river receded each November, people dug shallow wells called jemmam in the sandy riverbed, shunning pools of standing water for animal consumption. Although jemmam were no longer in constant use after the well was built, the well was closed so often that one could almost always find them dug in the riverbed. The location of these shallow wells shifted as the river receded, with people digging new holes following along where the subsurface water was closest. When children and others fetched water from the riverbed, they usually had only to clean and drain an existing jemmam to begin drawing water.

Reaching the moister area of the riverbed, Sofia chose a fairly large jemmam with about five centimeters of water at its bottom. She kneeled on the damp sand surrounding the hole and reached down to neaten its walls using the edge of her small enamel bowl to smooth the sides. She walked through the well in order to neaten its other side, and then scooped out all of the water in the hole and poured it onto the sand. A girl of about thirteen years old joined her at the edge of the shallow well. Sofia and this girl spent the next couple of minutes scooping out the water as it filtered into the jemmam. They continued this procedure, taking turns using Sofia's bowl until the water was relatively free of sediment. Sofia then drew two bowls of water in order to wash her bucket. As she did this, the far wall cracked. At this, she and the older girl, with the older child in the lead, broke the wall down further and expanded the well. They smoothed the new wall and scooped out the loose dirt. The whole process took about ten minutes. The older girl cleaned the jemmam again, scooping out the water until it cleared.

In the meantime, Sofia cleaned her feet by slogging through the pools of standing water nearby. She also cleaned her bucket thoroughly by scrubbing it with mud and standing water and then rinsing it with jemmam water. She then ran about twenty-five meters to another shallow well. Tasting and smelling the water to see if it was good, she quickly spit it out. "It's gross, and there's pee in it" she told whoever was listening, and ran back to the original well, where the older girl was still drawing water, trying to get rid of the sediments. The girls worked in tandem to fill the elder one's five-gallon jerry-can. The older girl scooped up the water as it trickled into the jemmam, and poured it into Sofia's bucket. Sofia scooped it up from there and decanted it into the jerry-can. Their careful procedure minimized turbidity. Whenever she inadvertently scooped up some sand, the older girl paused to pour out little mud figures that with time crouched along much of the jemmam's top edge. When the older girl's container was full, Sofia filled her own bucket neatly and carefully by herself. She lifted the bucket to her head and balanced it with grace and surety as she walked through the streambed and up its steep and gullied banks a few hundred meters to her house.

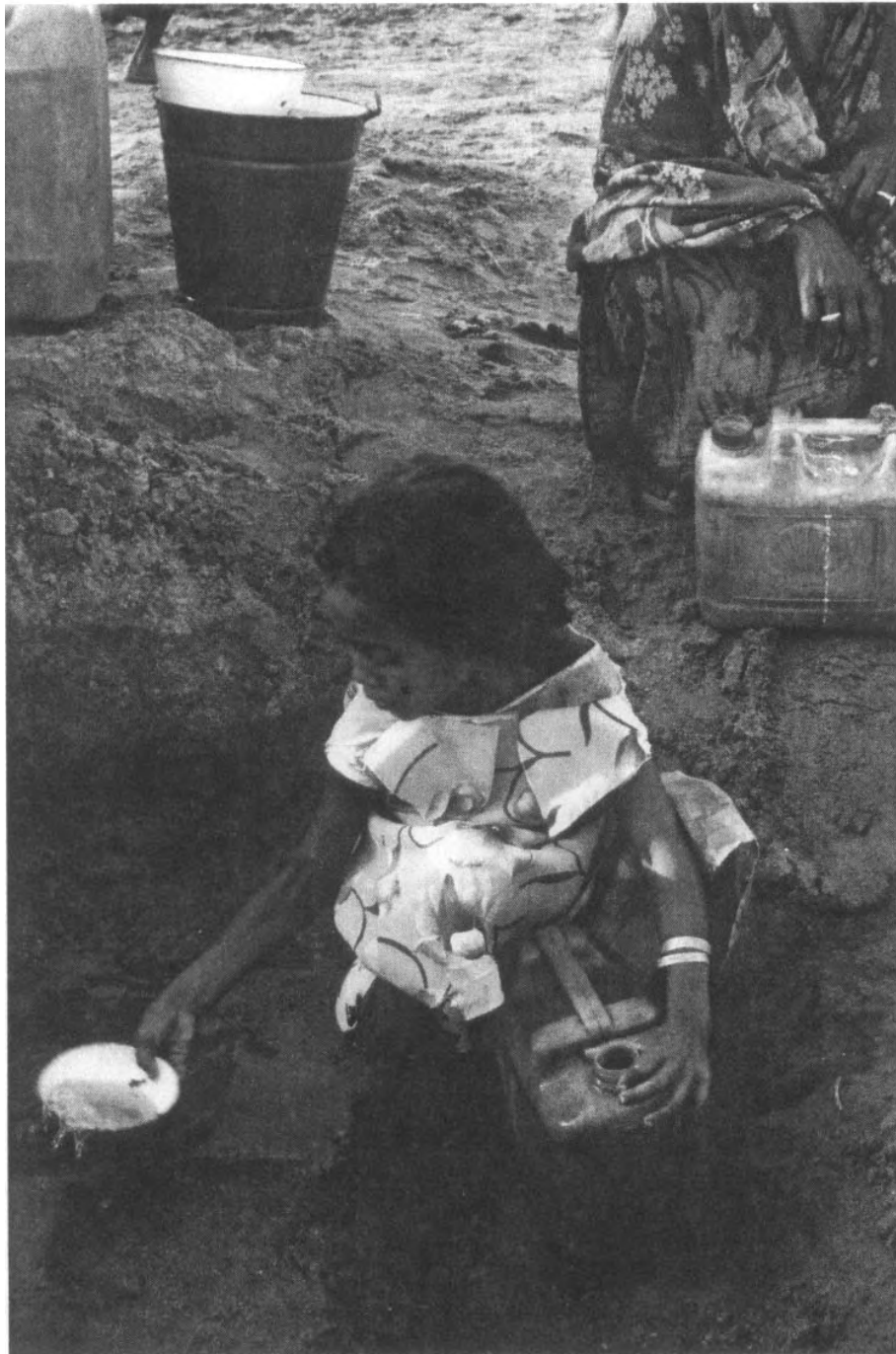


Figure 15. Children like Nowal learned the delicate art of drawing water from older children and women. Jemmam, the shallow wells dug in the sandy river bed as the water receded and disappeared, were once the main source of water in Howa. Even after the construction of two artesian wells, jemmam remained important as a backup water supply whenever the wells were closed, which was all too frequent.

As Sofia's experience attests, drawing clean water from the riverbed was a skill that required meticulous care and patience. Girls did this task more often than boys. Moreover, perhaps because of the skill required, it seemed that more women than usual drew water on days when the artesian well was closed. Procuring jemmam water was often a group effort in which children learned the technique and the qualities of a good well by observing and sharing the work with more experienced children or adults. I often observed adults guiding, instructing, and correcting children as they drew water from the riverbed. With several trips to fetch water in a day, children had the opportunity to constantly practice and develop their competence.

Drawing water from the artesian wells was a simpler task, involving gritty determination more than exacting skill. Children fetching well water were not required to make assessments about water quality or to construct and maintain a safe source. They had only to jostle with the crowds that attended the well during its limited operating hours and secure a place near one of the spigots. As with fetching water from the river or canal, physical skill and strength were required to lift and carry the containers back home. For children of ten years, vessels might be one-gallon plastic jugs—courtesy of Mobil Oil—buckets of a similar size or slightly larger, or five-gallon jerry-cans of plastic or tin. Girls generally transported these containers on their heads, although some of them used donkeys to carry home a pair of the large jerry-cans. Head portage was not a skill learned by men in Howa, so when boys of about ten and older fetched water, they tended to use a donkey with a pair of five-gallon containers. Girls from a young age, on the other hand, started practicing carrying things around on their heads, and by ten years of age many were already quite adept at it, though not all were yet large enough to carry the five-gallon containers that women customarily used. Head bearing required girls to lift the vessels over their shoulders and relied on strong neck and shoulder muscles, along with well-developed balance. Using donkeys, on the other hand, embroiled boys and girls in tough games of seesaw as they cantilevered their loads on and off the donkey's back.

The importance of children's labor to water provision, and of water provision to the round of daily tasks that secured the reproduction of everyday life, cannot be overestimated. Of all the tasks in which children engaged, their labor was most significant here. Fetching water was unique among tasks associated with providing the means of existence because the contribution of children outweighed that of adults in the total time spent at the community level.⁴ Perhaps it was the routine nature of the task or maybe it was the sheer volume of work involved, but fetching water was in some ways the least playful of children's tasks. Of course, in the heat of the day it was simply fun to get wet, and everybody always got wet whether from treading in the puddles around the wells, jockeying for a place near the spigots, wading into the canal, or splashing their faces with the cool water of the jemmams. But these playful aspects of the task were subdued and so much a part of the work—which was fairly constrained, either because of the crowds at the well or because of the limited number of jemmams and the need for meticulous care in using them—that they went almost unremarked. Of course, with children involved, nothing—not even getting water in an arid land—was utterly serious.

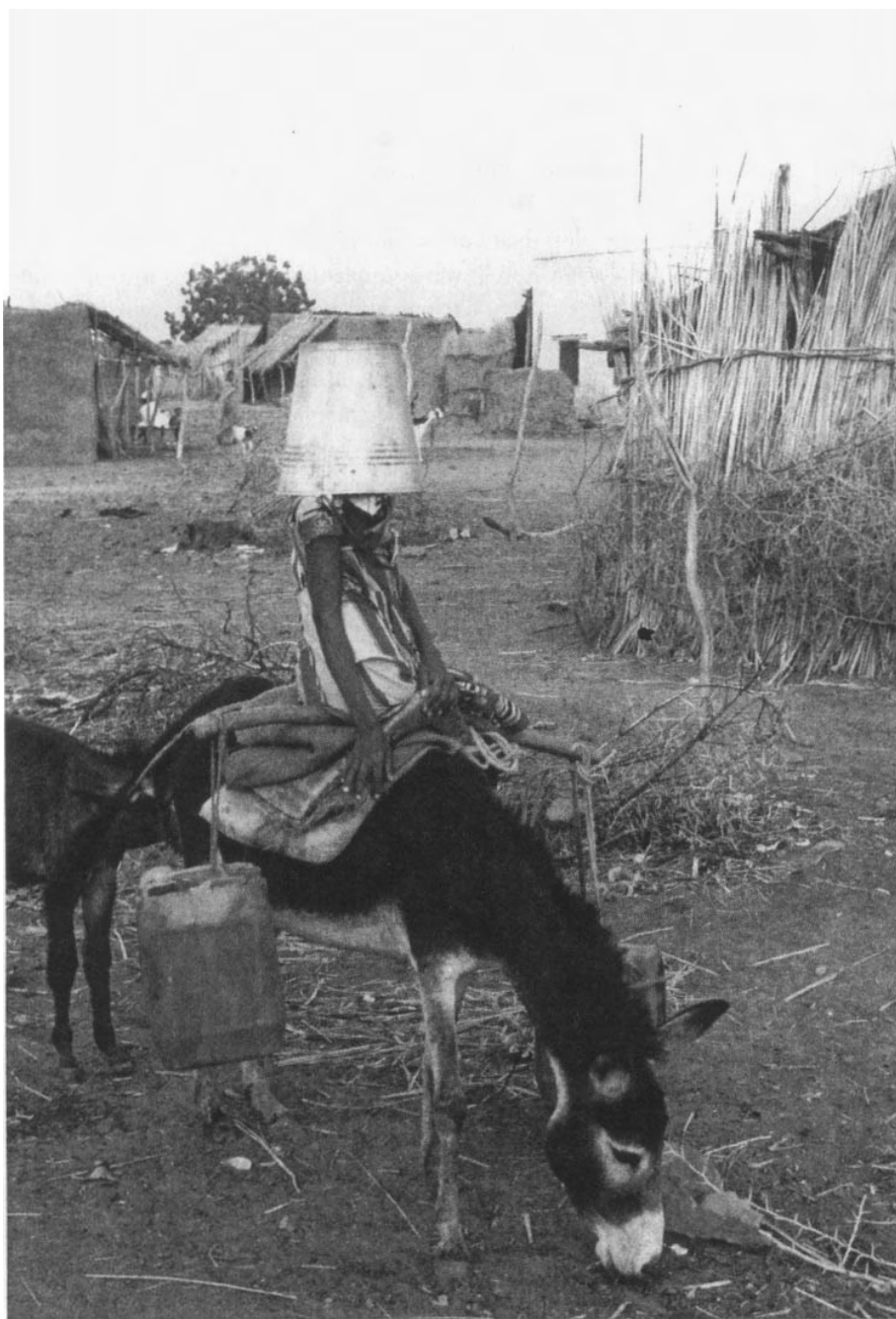


Figure 16. Even the most essential tasks were toyed with by children, whose irreverence permeated their routines.

Gathering Fuelwood

Collecting firewood was another matter entirely. While woodfuel was one of the crucial provisions supplied in large part by children, and consequently a task that absorbed much of their time, its procurement—almost always from outside the village bounds—left room and time for play.

It's mid-June and the sun is finally getting low in the sky. Everyone emerges from their shaded grass verandas to get one last chore in or share a bit of leisure. (Pick-up soccer games were popular with young men and boys late in the day, and it was the hour when lots of children played in the streets or open spaces of their courtyards.) Miriam and about five other girls were off to get wood in the East. They collected large acacia branches, knocking off the thorns and small branches with a large stick. In the midst of their gathering they ran into Talal and his brother with a couple of friends out chopping saplings for the kitchen Talal was building for his mother. Before too long the children descended into the riverbed together. Quite spontaneously, the boys decided to sing, using my small plastic water jug as a drum. As the boys sang a number of popular songs, the girls danced in the riverbed. The golden light of *'usur* (the hour before sunset) made this rare instance of older boys and girls playing together even more special.

With the exception of small amounts of wood for medicinal, veterinary, or cosmetic purposes, all of the wood burned in Howa was used for cooking. Fuelwood was collected by gathering sticks from the ground around dead or felled trees, chopping down trees or lopping off their branches, or burning charcoal from local trees. Children's labor was most significant in the first of these, collecting dead and felled branches or twigs, although they also helped adults by chopping wood and in the production of charcoal. I estimate that children and adolescents provided about 65 percent of the *gathered* wood used in their households. Here again, girls between eight and fourteen predominated. Ten of the children with whom I worked (six girls and four boys) collected wood regularly. Children were not the sole providers of household fuel, as they often were for water. Because of the nature of the work, children's contributions were augmented routinely with larger pieces gotten by adults and older siblings or through purchase. This is not to say that children's contribution to fuel procurement was insignificant. In most households children or teens provided the bulk of fuelwood consumed. All of the seven children working with me who did not provide fuel for their households—including the herdboys and children who assisted their elders with market-oriented charcoal production or scavenging—had older sisters who procured their households' fuelwood.

There were political-ecologic and task-specific reasons that the children's role in fuel provision was more auxiliary than in other tasks. Women generally cooked over a hot three-stone fire, for which they preferred wood that was over a meter long and more than an inch and a half in diameter. The best wood this size was available only by cutting, and most ten-year-old children could not wield an ax well enough to provide it. Much of this wood was procured by men or older boys, and occasionally by the women

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themselves. In addition, local deforestation—exacerbated by the Suki Project—had significantly increased the distance traveled and time required for fuel collection in Howa. Children routinely walked between half an hour and an hour to find wood. Moreover, the sort of wood that remained near the village had to be collected more frequently than before because it was from less valued species or smaller trees. These factors of time and distance led to both the increased participation of children collecting wood near the village and the need to supplement it with larger pieces cut further afield by older household members or others. Finally, even without the stress on the local wood supply, the amount of fuel required to cook two or three meals a day, coupled with the average load a ten-year-old child could carry, required children to collect wood about every three days in most households. Given domestic chores, such as child care, errand running, cooking, and cleaning; other responsibilities, such as drawing water, farming, and shepherding; school attendance; and children's need and desire for free time, many children in Howa were unable to collect woodfuel frequently enough to cover the bulk of their household's requirements.

Nevertheless, children's contribution to fuel provision in the village as a whole was substantial. Thirteen of the seventeen children working with me helped provide fuelwood, eight of them routinely. In most households, the branches and sticks collected by children composed at least half of the fuel they used.⁵ The land-use changes brought about by the agricultural project, along with other factors, had so stressed the woodlands nearby that there was little else for village households to burn. The altered environs not only had made cooking more arduous (with smokier fires and the extra work required as a result of poorer quality wood, for instance), but had increased children's work substantially. These increases were felt not only by children who regularly collected fuel, but also by children who normally did not. Among the seventeen children working with me, for instance, one boy and one girl were called on in this ad hoc way. When household supplies ran low, each of them was sent to areas on the village perimeter to gather what wood they could. They usually had to resort to small or extremely poor quality bits of wood in these pinches.

Among those who did collect wood regularly, a camaraderie like that of the shepherds lightened the load, figuratively if not literally. Collecting wood, especially among girls, was usually a group activity. Awatif and a small group of her friends, for instance, spent many late afternoons collecting wood together. Living only a few steps from each other's houses made it easy to initiate work or play spontaneously, and these girls did most things together. The girls—three of whom, including Awatif, were students—enjoyed each other's company, and, like the herdboys, seemed to make a good time out of even the most mundane chores. Their pleasure in being together certainly did not detract from their sense of purpose in carrying out their work, however. To the contrary, the opportunity to work with friends ensured that chores would be more readily undertaken. As with herdboys, the girls' sociality worked to their households' advantage; if two or three girls were set to get wood, for instance, one or two others

might join them without any prodding from their mothers—and every bit of wood, whether needed that moment or not, was appreciated.

On an overcast morning in late June, Awatif and her friends head across the canal and north to an area known as the *tulh* (after a small stand of tulh [*Acacia seyal*]). Leaving their houses at six-thirty, the girls walk for about half an hour. They often collected wood from this area bordering the fields of the irrigation project, where trees were commonly felled for charcoal production or construction needs. The chopping left many smaller branches on the ground, which makes the girls' task easier because they need only cover a small area to find plentiful wood. Chatting as they walk, the girls carry rags and lengths of rope. The rope is to bundle the wood, while the rags cushion their load on the way home.

When we reach the open woodland of the tulh, the girls work steadily and swiftly at this familiar task. They make three separate trips to different parts of the site, each time returning to a central spot with full armloads of sticks and branches. After the third trip, each has amassed a tremendous amount of wood. The girls then begin sorting through their piles of wood, knocking off thorns and laying the sticks and branches neatly over long pieces of outstretched rope. Awatif and her friends each tie the rope loosely around her bundle and then work in pairs to tighten it. A girl sits on either side of the bundle holding one end of the rope and pressing the soles of her feet against the side of the wood bundle. Working in tandem, they tug the rope, rocking the soles of their feet against the wood and arching their backs to yank as hard as possible, producing neat and manageable bundles of wood. The girls roll up their rags and place them on their heads, bend over to put their heads down on the wood piles and then straighten up, pressing the wood to their heads. Awatif takes a bit longer to sort her wood, having collected more than she can carry. Even leaving some behind she seems to struggle a bit in lifting her heavy load, and is plagued all the way home by a broken flip-flop that she fixed by tying a string to a twig at the underside of the sole to create a makeshift thong.

Children's work in charcoal production was another matter entirely. Cutting the necessary wood, making and tending the kiln, and "harvesting" the charcoal was an intensive process lasting several days, and virtually no one under eighteen in Howa did this work on their own. Children often assisted their fathers and older relatives with charcoal making. Two of the boys who worked with me helped with the full range of tasks. Another couple of children, boy and girl cousins, occasionally helped their grandmother and great aunt scavenge bits of charcoal from spent kilns up to an hour's walk away in the wooded areas bordering the agricultural lands and further afield.⁶ Muna assisted with this task almost every time her grandmother went (two to three times a week during the hot dry months of May and June, when most of the local charcoal production took place), whereas Ismail accompanied her only on occasion, when he didn't have school. Even at that he joined her largely because of his curiosity and the good-natured rivalry between the children over whose experiences and activities were more interesting and wide-ranging.⁷ Whatever the reasons that the children

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Figure 17. In the absence of an adequate supply of larger wood, girls collected bundles of branches such as these several times a week to fuel their mothers' cooking fires. Compressing the bundles between their feet, the girls carried them on their heads for the half-hour walk back to the village.

accompanied their grandmother, when they were out with her it was hard work, and even when both of them were there, not much play. Over the weeks Muna collected enough charcoal to fill a couple of sacks that she sold, with her father's assistance, for the equivalent of US\$2.19 each, giving the proceeds to her mother. What Ismail collected was used in part by his household; the rest was contributed to his grandmother's collection.

Another child, Sami, participated in charcoal production regularly. Sami was from a relatively poor nontenant household. His father was an older man who earned about half of his annual income from the production and sale of charcoal. Except during the height of the rainy season from July through October, when charcoal was not produced and agricultural work was available, Sami accompanied his father almost daily to cut and gather wood for both the production of charcoal and household consumption. They traipsed over an hour away to find adequate supplies of favored species like tulh (*Acacia seyal*) or, more rarely, *hejlij* (*Balanites aegyptiaca*). While Sami and his father cut wood, the latter with considerably more speed and dexterity, Sami's thirteen-year-old sister, Maha, collected felled branches to haul home for household cooking. Besides cutting and transporting wood, Sami and Maha assisted their father every few days when he built an earthen kiln next to their house to carbonize the charcoal. The children also helped their father tend the kiln for the two or three days that the charcoal smoldered and with bagging it for sale either in the village or a nearby town. Even though the children goofed around when they went out each day, their work was not as playful as that of children out only with other kids to collect wood. As assistants to

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their father, Sami and Maha were not in control of the rhythm of their work or its duration, and unlike the herdboys or children off on their own to do various tasks, these children had few opportunities for “stolen” moments of unattended spontaneous play. Nevertheless, a different form of play erupted around the edges.

July. The rains were starting and charcoal production would soon be winding down. On a bit of a busman's holiday, Sami spent part of the morning building an extraordinary miniature charcoal mound out of small pieces of wood. Crouching on the ground near his house, he made a small mound of grass and then placed the wood teepee-style around it. He covered the cone in another layer of grass and then sprinkled fistfuls of dirt mixed with dung over the whole thing. The whole enterprise took about ten minutes, whereupon Sami ran to get a burning coal from a neighbor's fire. Touching it to the grass through a small opening he'd left, Sami ignited the *comina*. As he covered the opening with a *doleib* stone, Sami announced with great satisfaction that the charcoal would be ready by afternoon. When Sami unpacked the small mound later in the day, he gave the charcoal to his mother—an indulgence she rarely got from her husband's routine charcoal production.

In this activity, Sami, the eternal assistant in making charcoal, had a chance to sequence and control the full range of tasks associated with the activity. His playful work offered Sami a sense of mastery and his workful play produced small amounts of charcoal for his appreciative mother.

Agriculture

Dramatic enactments of work in miniature were most striking in the arena of agriculture. Children like Rashid, described in chapter 1, whiled away languid afternoons absorbed in endless games of “tenancies” and the subsistence version, “bildat.” Engaged in the full course of activities associated with both tenant and subsistence farming, the boys played in the shaded areas of their houseyards, fashioning miniature hoes and tractors to work the beds they raised, graded, furrowed, planted, ridged, watered, weeded, and harvested. As with Sami's charcoal kiln, these games gave children the opportunity and pleasure of working out in miniature the sequencing and coordination of tasks in which they generally participated as assistants. Their attention to detail was extraordinary and their resourcefulness with materials exquisite.

The play of agriculture, like Sami's playful kiln construction, ricocheted and intertwined with other aspects of the children's time. In the work of agriculture, which was, of course, the main productive activity in Howa, ten-year-olds worked as auxiliaries, assisting their parents, elder siblings, and others in myriad tasks. None of these tasks—which included seed preparation, clearing, sowing, weeding, and harvesting—was the responsibility of children alone, although most children over eight years old contributed to each of them. Their contribution was particularly significant in the labor-intensive tasks of seed preparation, planting, weeding, and harvesting. All but

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one of the seventeen children participated in at least one agricultural task during the year; ten participated in seed preparation (shelling groundnuts), three in clearing, eight in planting, eleven in weeding, three in bird scaring, and eight in harvesting. Almost all of the children between nine and thirteen years old from tenant households helped their parents carry out the full range of agricultural tasks, whether in project lands or outside. While children from nontenant households often worked in the fields of members of their extended families or for a wage or piece rate in the tenancies of other villagers, they did not engage in agricultural work as commonly as did the children of tenants, even as paid workers.⁸

Participation of the greatest number of children was facilitated by the long school vacation, which coincided with the rainy season from late June through September. Although school vacations were set by the Ministry of Education to enable teachers in rural schools to return to their home districts during the difficult rainy months, the timing of these vacations was also intended to free children to assist their parents during one of the busiest times of the agricultural season. Given the intensified labor requirements of irrigated cultivation compared to rain-fed, it was critically important that children be available to work during the rainy months. In many families the labor of youngsters was necessary to complete various agricultural tasks, and my research suggests that if these children were unavailable to work because of school, many of them would be forced to drop out. School attendance in Howa traced a knife edge between households' current needs for their children's labor and their attempts to improve the children's prospects for the future. The edge was sharpened by the economic straits brought about by the production relations and generally low incomes associated with the agricultural project. "Development" often takes place on the backs of children, and crop mortgaging was not the only kind of mortgaging that enabled struggling farm tenants to get by.

Farmers in Howa argued that the cultivation practices of the agricultural project were more arduous than those before it had been. There were a number of reasons for this. Cotton, groundnuts, and sorghum, the only crops allowed on project lands (the last, only beginning in 1981), were sown using a digging stick, rather than broadcast, as with sesame. Planting this way was time consuming. Farmers reported, and my observations corroborated, that a tenancy of approximately ten acres took a minimum of several days to plant. Often, as many nine- to thirteen-year-old children as were available in a household would assist their father or older brother with sowing. Eight of the children with whom I worked helped plant their households' and/or extended families' fields. One of these children, Sami, whose father was not a tenant, also did this work as a paid field hand.

Early July and the rains have started. Awatif and her twelve-year-old sister and thirteen-year-old brother had been going to the fields each day to help their father plant. Their father left at dawn to take advantage of the coolest part of the day and the three children followed just after six. Awatif rode the donkey, sitting atop a large sack of sorghum that rested on a digging stick and an ax. While her brother and sister dropped some grain

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at the village mill, Awatif continued straight to the footbridge over the major canal. She seemed quite comfortable on the donkey, even though her small size made it difficult for her to mount it by herself. We zig-zagged along the canal system for about an hour and a half to reach the family's tenancy. The minute we got there, Awatif's brother Osman ran to a wooded area within view of the family's field and set up the net snare he'd brought along to trap birds. Awatif helped him set the trap while their sister joined their father at work clearing the irrigation ditch bounding the field. After the trap was set, Awatif and Osman joined the other two in the field. Osman immediately took up the digging stick and rapidly went up and down the rows making holes about fifteen centimeters apart with every step. His sisters followed his path in different rows, each carrying a small bowl of sorghum from which they dropped several kernels of grain into each hole, covering them up in the same movement by sliding soil in with their feet. They kept a fairly leisurely pace up and down the rows in the wake of the speeding digging stick. Osman ran off repeatedly to check his bird trap. On occasion he didn't return before the girls finished planting all of the holes drilled, at which point they would either take a break or one of them would take up the digging stick and continue in their brother's path. Awatif's sister accomplished this task with considerably more skill than she did. One time as Osman ran off, his father looked up from the irrigation ditch he was cleaning and shouted over, "Are you here to work or play?" Undaunted, Osman checked his trap anyway, but never snared anything that morning.



Figure 18. Just after sunrise Awatif and her sister and brother headed out to their family's tenancy a few kilometers away to assist their father with planting chores. Working early to avoid the hottest parts of the day, the children—if not their father—were usually back in the village by late morning.

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Figure 19. Skirting the edge between work and play, bird snaring was a favorite pastime of boys in Howa. Taking a break from planting sorghum (or was it the other way around?), Awatif and her brother set his homemade net trap, hoping to catch a few doves or migratory birds with some filched grain.

Osman's behavior and his father's response point again to the playful nature of much of children's work and the purposive setting for much of their play. Even in early adolescence, when a child's work contribution is relied on by his or her family, Osman was lured to "fall down on the job" by the prospect of trapping a few birds. (See Fortes 1970, 59–61, for an example of the distractions found and created by children in northern Ghana protecting their families' crops from birds, and Ammar 1966 for a description of the parental response to such lack of discipline in Upper Egypt.)

Even more laborious was weeding the cotton and groundnut fields. This demanding effort forced many tenants to tap the labor of their young sons and, on occasion, their daughters. Because the majority of Howa's tenants could not afford to hire people to assist with agricultural tasks on a regular basis (though most hired field hands during the harvest), the labor of children was all the more important in the face of new tasks and work regimes imposed by the project. Eleven of the children working with me, eight boys and three girls (seven of them from tenant households), participated in weeding; three of the boys did so for pay.

Weeding marked a significant departure from pre-project regimes of work. Project regulations mandated not only four weedings, but that the heavy clay soils be weeded with a short-handled hoe (*kedunka* or *toriya*) that required farmers to bend over as they worked. Unlike the tools that were traditionally used (the *malod ga'ad* [standing hoe] and *malod wagif* [sitting hoe]), the short-handled hoe was back

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breaking as well as clod breaking, and many complained about it. When children weeded, they usually used properly scaled kedunkas fashioned for them by local toolmakers. Some children, however, used a “sitting hoe,” and thus could sit or squat as they worked. Many old-timers also insisted on using pre-project hoes, despite the objections of project authorities.

The arduousness of weeding notwithstanding, harvest was the most labor-intensive part of the agricultural year. Harvest tasks required the labor of almost every able-bodied family member in most tenant households. Some families with tenancies more than a forty-five-minute walk from the village even built temporary shelters in their fields (*cambo*) and moved the household out there for days at a time during the weeks when the harvest work was most intense. Children as young as seven helped their parents, grandparents, and older siblings pick cotton and pull up groundnuts. Here again, children of tenants were more likely to work than others, even among those working for pay. Indeed, all through the village, children, particularly girls ten years and older and most women over thirty-five, worked for a piece-wage during the harvest. Pioneering the public–private partnerships that have become so prevalent in recent years, even the school got into the act. It had become a tradition for the school children and their teachers to spend one week each year picking cotton in the fields of various tenants. In exchange, the school was paid by the Suki Project at the going rate. In the harvest of 1980–81, for instance, the school was paid the equivalent of US\$250, which was used to purchase basic supplies.

In September, about a month before the sorghum, groundnut, and cotton harvests begin, many of the vegetables planted around the borders of the tenancies or in the few remaining bildat (rain-fed fields outside of the irrigation scheme) were ripe and ready for picking. Among them was a prickly variety of okra known as weka that thrived in and around the irrigated fields. Weka, a staple of the local diet, was sliced and sun dried on burlap sacks sprawled all around houseyards immediately after it was harvested. The dried rounds were eventually pounded into a coarse powder in large wooden mortars and reconstituted throughout the year to thicken the daily stew. When the pods ripened, women and children were out nearly every day to harvest them.

Ismail has been picking weka for the past week or so. He's wrapped his hand in a rag to protect it from the minuscule prickly thorns covering the okra. The cloth was cumbersome and made picking somewhat awkward and difficult. Harvesting weka even without the cloth was difficult enough for Ismail because the okra pods had to be yanked hard from the stems and some of the higher ones were out of his reach. He collected only enough to fill an old stew pot brought for the occasion, and all too abruptly called it a day. While after a week of picking, there was not much left on the plants for the time being, it was clear that Ismail simply did not like the task (not many people did) and cut it off as early as possible. He hardly approached it with the quixotic zeal he had when he was trying to catch fish earlier that morning or the cheerful energy he had for most of his chores. He picked reluctantly and left several pods

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on the plants either through laziness or boredom, and did not seem to notice or care that some weka remained unpicked.

Ismail's lethargy notwithstanding, the energy expended picking weka from mid-September until late October was impressive. Not only did each household try to harvest enough for its substantial annual dietary requirement, but it was also picked for sale. Women were responsible for its harvest and entitled to any money earned from the sale of surplus supplies. Thus, there was material incentive for women or their agents—most commonly children—to harvest as much of the fast-growing vegetable as possible as soon as it was ripe. These efforts were all the more intense given that the faster weka was harvested, the more pods would reach fruition.

Toward the end of the weka harvest, the sorghum and groundnuts ripened. Following the groundnut harvest in late November and early December, the cotton crop ripened and was ready for picking. Depending on the schedule of other agricultural operations in a given season, the harvests of cotton and groundnuts often overlapped. As was discussed in chapter 2, this overlap was anticipated by the architects of the agricultural project, but was predicated on a mechanized groundnut harvest. For most farmers this had not come to pass, either because of mechanical breakdowns or because it was unaffordable, placing a great strain on family labor.

As all-encompassing as agricultural work was, it was still infiltrated by play. As with herding or wood collecting, children's play and work in the fields often overlapped and intertwined. Children goofed around and meandered aimlessly in getting out to and returning from the fields, for instance, sometimes having a dip in the major canal or wandering off to socialize with other children out gathering wood, herding, or working in their families' fields. More commonly, play punctuated the children's work in the fields, providing a distraction. Like Awatif's brother Osman, many set up hand-made bird traps near the fields. Although boys made and deployed the net traps, their sisters were often part of the enterprise. The children would roll the snare into a narrow strip and cover it with dirt, scattering sorghum—usually the very seed they were meant to be planting—on the ground in front of it. Stretching a long cord from the buried net toward where they were working, the children would return to work, keeping an eye out for any birds alighting on the sorghum. If birds were spotted, these wayward field hands would run to pull the cord and snare their prey. While many times the birds were scared off by the children's approach, sometimes they were actually trapped, at which point one of the older boys (usually a teenager) would systematically slit their necks with a small knife or a sharpened piece of tin. While successfully netting what might be a few dozen small birds for later eating would delight parents almost as much as the children, the distraction and constant back-and-forth to check the traps could drive adults determined to complete a task around the bend. In these cases, the children's play—which had its own workful elements—might be inhibited by their elders' agendas and impatience. But if trapping was an activity of boy and bird, the call to work enacted a similar dance between boy and man. By my accounts, the boys were ahead in both arenas.

Collecting Wild Foods

While birds trapped by children and young men were something of a rare treat, other wild foods figured more significantly in the local diet according to the season. Children usually picked or gathered these noncultivated foods for their own or their households' consumption. Ten of the seventeen children working with me procured wild foods for their households. Most of these were seasonal fruits and vegetables, although a few children also hunted and one had tried his hand at fishing.

A small number of uncultivated vegetables, among them the greens, *mulayta* (*Picridium trigitanum* Desf) and *khudra* (*Corchorus olitorius*), and a variety of uncultivated okra known generically as *weka* (*Hibiscus esculentus* L), grew in and around the tenancies, and were gathered almost daily during the latter months of the rainy season. Three of the children regularly harvested these vegetables, providing an important addition to their families' diets. The greens were among the only fresh vegetables eaten in Howa over the year. But there was an alarming underside to their consumption. The greens were treated with an herbicide used regularly in the tenancies. In questioning Suki Project authorities about this, I was told that the herbicide, known to them by its U.S. brand name, Zorial®, killed grasses but not broad-leafed plants.⁹ While *khudra* and *molayta* were broad-leafed, they were sprayed nevertheless with little regard for whether they were consumed by animals, and no regard or seeming awareness that these and other plants deemed "weeds" by the project were consumed and handled by the local population, particularly children. I was disturbed to find children's bare arms, faces, and clothing coated with a fine white dust after they gathered the treated greens. While of course the chemicals, which the children knowingly called *mobeed* (toxin), were washed off both children and vegetables, the risks of exposure through ingestion or contact were unknown to the local population. The bitterness of the greens may go well beyond their taste.¹⁰

Many of the wild foods favored in Howa came from trees, and were not so hazardous to gather or consume. Neither were they as easy to come by as the vegetables that dotted the irrigated areas. Thanks to widespread deforestation in the vicinity, which had affected both the range of species and the number of trees, the availability of preferred fruits, seeds, and roots had by all accounts decreased significantly in recent years. Many of the fruits that in the past had been enjoyed by the entire population during good years and had been a famine food source in bad, had become largely children's foods. These increasingly rare foods, such as *lalog* (from *Balanites aegyptiaca*), *nubg* (from *Zizaphus spinachristi*), *aradeib* (tamarind from *Tamarindus indica*), and to a lesser extent, *humbock* (from *Capparis decidua*), were eaten almost exclusively by children who went in search of them or happened upon them in excursions in and around the village. Some fruits that were once freely available, such as *lalog*, *aradeib*, and, to a lesser extent, *nubg*, had become commodities for sale in nearby markets (see Tully 1988, 90, for a discussion of the same phenomenon in western Sudan). To compensate, perhaps, a few *Zizaphus spinachristi* and *Capparis decidua* had been planted in the village by individual residents. In season, their thorny branches dripped with old flip-flops,

sticks, and odd shoes, which testified to the sport of children getting fruit by whacking the trees with whatever came to hand.

The most prized wild fruit in the area was the doleib. This large, sticky, sweet, and stringy orange fruit is from the tall fan palm known by the same name (*Borassus aethiopicum*). The locals called it a “Kauli mango” after the nearby area where large stands were found, but I was sad to discover after months of anticipation that, except for the color, doleibs were a far cry from any mango I’d ever had. The doleib tree had grown commonly along much of the Dinder River, but by the 1980s coverage near the village had been reduced to two isolated and relatively small stands a few kilometers away. These treasured groves had been brought under the protection of the Forestry Department and cutting was forbidden. Apart from its fruit, the doleib was an important and versatile tree resource. It was used in construction and fencing, and its various parts were used widely as tools and household implements. Its decline, then, was due to fairly intense cutting for a variety of local uses, as well as extensive felling for commercial purposes. Natural regeneration of the palm was thwarted not only because the fruit was widely collected both to eat and to sell, but also because the succulent root of the doleib seedling was considered a delicacy and young trees were uprooted regularly.

The doleib was also important as a living tree resource. Its tall and graceful beauty was a source of pleasure and pride for people of the area. Doleib groves were special microenvironments that offered shade and shelter to wildlife. The only remaining baboons in the region were found there. The larger of these two groves, known simply as “the doleibs,” was on a bend in the river about five kilometers from Howa, just across the river from the next settlement downstream. It was a spot favored by almost everyone in Howa and its significance for people was striking. For months before going there, I heard about the beauty of the trees, about the wonderful fruit that grew there, about how cool it was in the shady grove, and about the baboons who lived in the treetops.

Certainly the biggest attraction of the doleibs was the large and fleshy fruit that ripened during May and June. During these months young and old people alike beat a path from the village to the trees. Most of these trips were to gather fruit for individual and household consumption, but some young men and several children collected fruit to sell back in the village for the equivalent of five to ten cents apiece. Several times in the season local merchants drove their trucks out to the doleibs and hired young men to collect truckloads of fruit to sell in regional markets.

Most children in Howa between nine and fourteen went to the doleibs to eat the sweet fruits as they ripened and fell from the trees, and to collect a few to take home to their families. Seven of the children working with me collected doleibs. For some children, the prospect of all that good eating, combined with their entrepreneurial plans, led to excited flights of fancy about expeditions to the grove. Talal, for example, came over almost nightly at the start of the season to borrow flashlight batteries to carry out his rather grandiose plans to gather and sell doleibs. Each night he had a plan to get up early, ride his donkey out to the groves before dawn, and sleep under a tree while (in his mind) the fruit crashed down around him. He figured this would give him an

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edge on village slugabeds in collecting the most doleibs. He raved about having the fruit sold before his friends wiped the sleep from their eyes. But even the bright sparkle that lit his eyes each evening could not dislodge the sleep from them come first light, and each morning when the sun was well above the horizon it seems he awoke, surprised to still be in bed and then trundled sheepishly back to return the batteries. Perhaps the planning was more fun than the execution; in any case, Talal never made a killing in doleibs.

For Awatif, ten-year-old Suad, their sisters, and their friends, the planning had been going on for a few weeks, but the execution was spontaneous. One Friday morning when school was out, the girls—twelve in total, ranging in age from eight to fifteen—decided to dispense with collecting wood and go instead to the doleibs. In granting them permission to go there rather than collecting wood, the girls' mothers had requested that they bring back *wekab*, a starchy ash used for thickening bean and other stews, made by burning the calyx-bearing branches of the doleib palm. These branches fell under the weight of the fruit and, along with piles of fronds and crushed fruit, thickly covered the ground under the trees.

We set off at 6:45 across the hard-packed and sharply dissected *kerrib* land northeast of the well. All of the girls except Awatif were carrying small containers of water and/or larger buckets and containers for carrying back things from the palm grove. The walk was pleasant and cool thanks to the cloud cover and strong breezes. As we moved away



Figure 20. Trips to the doleib palm grove along a bend in the Dinder were a highlight of May and June when the fruits ripened. Making the trek to eat their fill and have an adventure, Suad and her friends collect masses of palm branches to burn. The starchy ash known as *wekab* was requested by their mothers, who used it to thicken stews.

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from the village the terrain changed from the pale gullied kerrib to dark cracked clayey soil dotted with scrub and a few thorn trees. The latter was an area of rain-fed cultivation, but most of these bildat belonged to people in the village across the river from the doleibs, which had not been included in the irrigation project. Nearer to the grove and river the area evolved into an acacia forest that had been almost completely cut despite or maybe because of government protection. Abutting this area of stumps were the doleibs.

The walk took just over an hour. As soon as we arrived the girls ran in all directions looking for and collecting the choicest fruit from the seemingly limitless number strewn about the area. They devoured several fruits apiece, seeming to relish each sticky bite. Finally sated, they began the task of producing wekab for their mothers by collecting fallen branches from all around the grove and bringing them to a small clearing in the trees. In the meantime, Awatif and a few of the younger girls found some baboons high in one of the trees and excitedly pointed them out to us. Awatif followed the lead of some boys who were throwing doleib stones at the baboons. Luckily for the baboons, her throw rose only about three meters toward its target way up in the tree. Growing bored, she continued to wander around the area looking playfully for select fruit while her sister Shaddiya, as well as Suad and several of the older girls kept collecting branches. While they toiled, the younger girls cracked the doleibs open by banging them together or hitting them against the trees. Burying their faces in fruit after fruit, they devoured them with obvious pleasure. After some more feasting they climbed a termite mound nearby and from the top belted out the call to prayer at the top of their lungs for about two minutes.

All this while, Suad and the older girls were off in different directions collecting branches. They returned after about fifteen minutes, loaded down again and were joined by the younger girls, who climbed down from their perch high on the termite mound and ran over to help carry the cumbersome branches back to the clearing. It was 9:00 and we had been at the doleibs for over an hour. Suad piled her branches high, rapidly set fire to them, and ran from the hot flames. While the fires burned, she and the older girls fooled around on the sidelines, their turn to enjoy the fruit.

When the flames subsided about half an hour later, all twelve girls set off for water in the nearby riverbed. They ran down the embankment and diagonally across the riverbed to a deep jemmam near the opposite shore. They washed their legs, hands, and faces before they drank and filled their buckets. An older boy nearby climbed into the jemmam, which was about a meter deep, and got a footing on its wet sandy edge. From there he drew water that the girls used to fill their individual buckets. Buckets splashing, the girls ran back across the river singing, reaching the still smoldering fires at 9:55. Now it was the older girls who set off in search of fruit. Awatif stayed behind, slowly eating a doleib. The others returned five minutes later with more fruit and still more branches that they dropped on the ground. Using branches with fanlike fronds as brooms or rakes, the girls swept the embers outward and sprinkled them with the water. A few minutes later they swept their doused ashes (wekab) into their buckets.

Suad tried to pick up the small bits of ash that the broom missed and burned her hands in the process. She then got a piece of bark to shovel the remaining ashes into her bucket. As soon as the last ashes were in her bucket, Suad went off for still more branches. She returned after a few minutes and set the new pile of branches on fire. While they burned, she ate another couple of *doleibs* and then completed the whole process again, including another trip to the river.

Throughout this time, Awatif was “chain eating” *doleibs*, no sooner dropping the husk of one than immediately picking up another. She was a picture of complete absorption, sitting on one *doleib* with her face buried almost constantly in another. The air was pungent as the sweet smell of the fruit mixed with the acrid smoke of the burning branches and the girls in their bright flowered dresses wove through the clattering layers of branches and fronds on the ground.

With the second fires doused, each girl filled her bucket or bowl with additional *wekab* and topped the damp pile with several fruits. They lifted these heavy containers onto their heads and set off for the village. On the way out of the grove we ran into Osman, Awatif's thirteen-year-old brother, who had come out by donkey to collect palm branches to use in the construction of shades and verandas. Awatif convinced him to give her a ride back to the village. She, Suad, and a few other girls helped him to load the branches onto the animal's sides. The rest of the girls waited and did not set off for the village until noon. The walk back was hot, but for the first twenty to thirty minutes everyone kept a brisk pace. We rested for a few minutes in what shade we could find under one of the only trees around. After this stop we sprang ahead of the girls and rushed home for rest and water. We reached the village just before 1:00 and turned back to see the girls resting again, this time in the open sun about four hundred meters in the distance.

It is doubtful that any woman in Howa would send a child to get this ash specifically, and only two children working with me procured it over the season. But given the appeal of a trip to the *doleibs*, that was a moot point. Women had only to take advantage of the opportunity presented by their daughters' eagerness to visit the palm grove. For their part, the girls loved to go in order to eat their fill of *doleibs*, to bring fruit home to enjoy later with their families, and to have an outing in the treasured and exotic grove. Work, play, and wonder were almost indistinguishable on excursions like these.

If *doleibs* were a fruit enjoyed by everyone in the village, there were other plants that were consumed solely by children. Among these were *suteb*, the bulbous root of a plant that grew during the rainy season in the drowned *mayas*. While adults said that *suteb* could and would be eaten during food shortages, they did not eat them as a matter of course, despite liking them. This was mostly because with shepherds as competition, they did not get the chance. Herdboys sometimes managed to enlist one of the scrawny but speedy herd dogs to snare a rabbit to cook in the field. Like *suteb*, the rabbits caught by herdboys rarely made it back to the village.

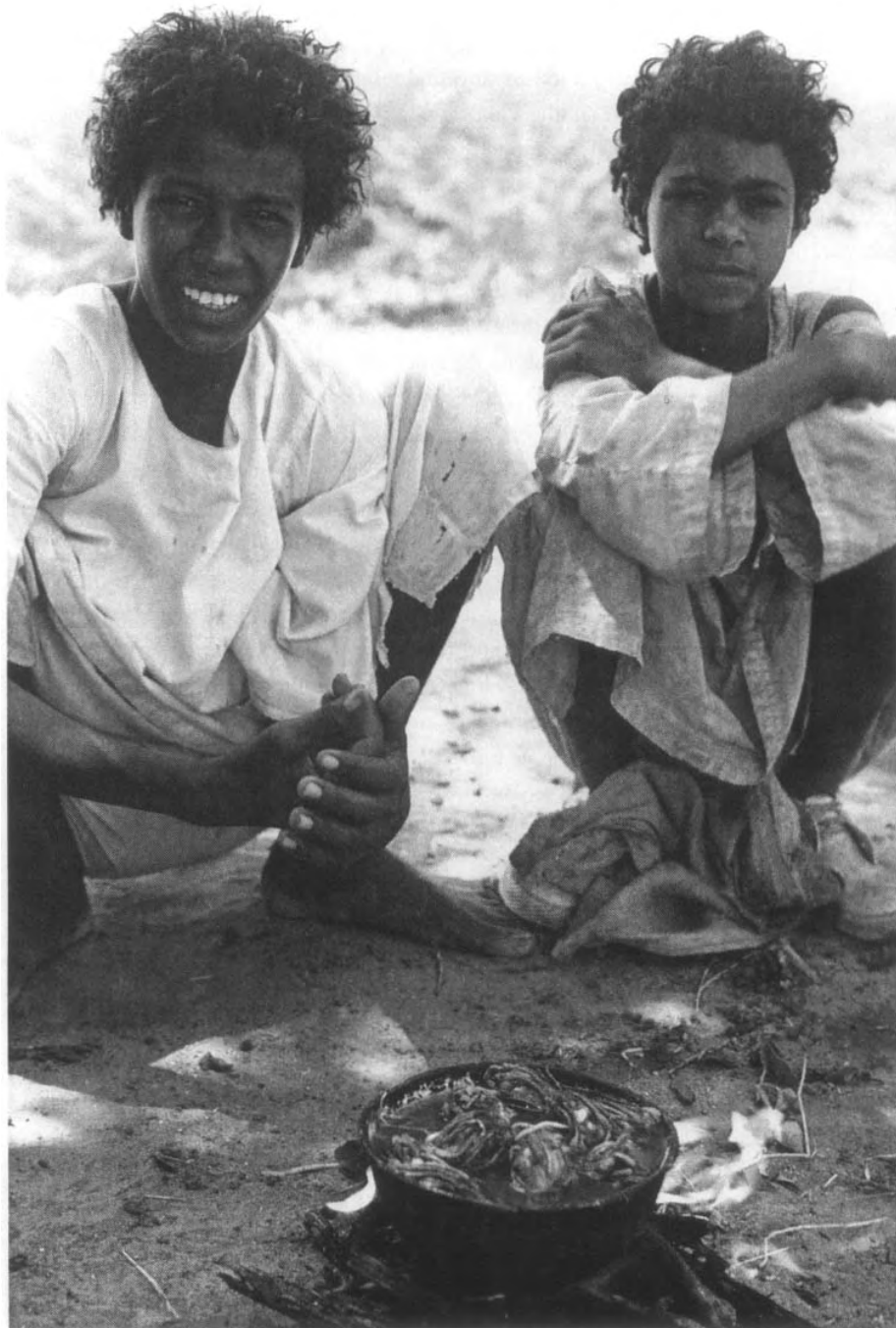


Figure 21. During the rainy season shallow pools formed in depressions all around the village. Determined water lilies soon sprouted in these pools, and even more determined herdboys waded in to pluck them. Boiled or roasted, the lily's starchy roots, called suteb, were a favorite seasonal breakfast for shepherds. Like the rabbits and other delicacies occasionally snared by herdboys, suteb never made it back to the village for the pleasure of others.

Other children hunted, trapped, or fished, although only bird trapping was of any economic or nutritional significance to their households. Three of the children, two boys and a girl, assisted their older brothers or other male relatives in trapping doves and several varieties of small birds that descended on the area during the rainy season. While these bite-sized birds were consumed most often within the extended family, sometimes upward of a hundred birds were trapped in a good day. Boys tried to sell surplus birds within the village for a few cents each. Of the children working with me, only Ahmed, who worked with his twelve-year-old uncle, engaged in trapping at this level. The other two children were still learning the techniques of trapping, and like most adolescent hunters in Howa, where hunting and trapping were not considered economic activities of any import, they and their brothers approached it more as a sport than as an income-producing activity.

Similarly, fishing was not an economic activity of any significance in Howa, and fish did not figure in the local diet at all. Nevertheless, some children in Howa (as well as a few adults) fished in the irrigation canals on occasion. As with hunting or trapping, almost all of those who fished were older than ten years. Among those working with me, only Sami fished during my stay in Howa, and that (fruitless) expedition to the canal was his first time. Ismail, whose uncles fished on occasion, was enraptured one day on his way back from helping with the harvest by the scores of catfish literally jumping from the canal near his father's tenancy. Balanced precariously on the bank of the canal, he had tried desperately to catch some fish by holding a large acacia branch across the canal in the wild hope that they would impale themselves on the thorns. In the wake of his quixotic venture, Ismail made plans for a fishing expedition, with clear delight at the prospect of eating his catch. Like Talal's predawn trips to the *doleibs*, the outing never quite materialized, but the pleasure of its anticipation was delicious.

I have perhaps dwelled more on these wild food expeditions than on other activities, such as agriculture, that consumed more of children's time and were more important to local production and reproduction. For me, the wildness of these expeditions extends beyond the food sources because they embody the themes that drive my work. The children's diverse strategies of food collection reveal the playfulness of work and the workfulness of play; at the same time they show how children's autonomous and pleasurable practices were woven integrally into their households' productive and reproductive strategies. In another vein, the waning economic significance of children's (and others') strategies of food procurement from wild sources speaks volumes about the nature of changes in the local political ecology.

Work-Play and Social Transformation

The preceding narratives of children's everyday activities make clear that none of the major categories of children's environmental work were separable from play. Play overlapped with, punctuated, and enveloped work in ways that often made the two indistinguishable in children's lives. In other instances, children played at their present and

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future work in miniature dramatic games like “fields,” “store,” and “house.” Still other times play activities such as building projects, making miniature charcoal kilns, or going on wild food expeditions had a worklike aspect or outcome that nevertheless did not detract from their intrinsic pleasures. While work and play were mutually exclusive at times, their easy mesh in the children’s lives was striking. But these unities in time, space, and meaning were threatened by some of the political-economic, social, and political-ecological changes underway in Howa. Within ten years of the Suki Project’s inception, for instance, household labor dynamics had been altered substantially, leading, among other things, to increased demands on children’s time. The constricted political ecology brought about by the project had begun to change the nature of certain children’s tasks, such as procuring woodfuel and herding, because of declines in vegetation. Finally, the restricted land rights of the project ensured that future generations would have limited access to farm tenancies, and this had begun to change perceptions of the significance of formal schooling.

Each of these phenomena individually and collectively changed the everyday lives of children in Howa, impinging on the relationship between work and play in ways that anticipated and seemed to reinforce the stricter delineations between work and leisure time that characterize industrial capitalism. Under these conditions, work is valorized while play is trivialized as something done *only* in childhood or in time *off* from work. But the relationship between work and play is more vibrant and fertile than that, and in Howa its potency was still apparent. Not only did the weave between work and play illuminate the contours of a less alienated world toward which those intent on creating new social relations of production and reproduction in the future might strive, but the exquisite tension between the children’s work and play intensified the force of the interpretations and possibilities offered by looking at children’s activities through the Benjaminian lens of mimesis (see Benjamin 1978a; Buck-Morss 1989; Taussig 1993). For one, children’s playful activities, like play almost everywhere, remained a psychological reservoir, an oasis for imagining things and themselves differently, for experimenting with various social and cultural relations, and for exercising what Walter Benjamin (1978a) called the mimetic faculty, where, in the acts of seeing resemblances and creating similarities, the power of making something utterly new lies coiled. But this open-ended and even promissory quality of play as a means of transformation was made more powerful in this case by its active and intense relationship with work. In the shifting nexus between play, work, and social transformation, much was up for grabs in Howa.

Play as Transformation

While it appears that children almost everywhere engage in dramatic play that enables them to fantasize about and deal symbolically with the social roles and responsibilities they will be expected to assume as adults, these activities are misunderstood if they are seen solely in relation to the reproduction or maintenance of these communities. They

are as much, if not more, fantasy and invention as they are social learning. While the script may be one that follows and closely mimics certain familiar material social practices, such as those associated with farming, school, or shopping, each enactment is original. The children are actors, not simply re-actors imitating the life they see around them (see Schwartzman 1978). Anything can happen and it often does. While as in “real life” the tenant farmers tilling in the games of “fields” orchestrated by Rashid did not all make the same income, they did all receive at least some “china money” at the end of the season; a far cry from the adult world around them, this was a world that allowed all comers to continue to play. Despair and exclusion were likewise forestalled by the fact that each iteration of the games had different outcomes; the poor did not always get poorer, nor did the rich always get richer in the children’s dramatic play.

But perhaps more potently, the children were not simply rehearsing, or rehearsing for, the social relations they saw around them, but playing with such things as power, control, symbol, gesture, and routine, while being absorbed by their creative projects, social interplay, and imagination of mastery. As Gregory Bateson (1956) suggests in his classic article, “The Message ‘This Is Play,’” the processes of role-taking and role-changing in a world of make-believe render play itself a necessary cultural skill. Instead of addressing the texts of play as a means for learning particular skills and social knowledge, Bateson argues that perhaps the key skill acquired in play is the ability to enter an imaginary and symbolic world, because everyday life, as a set of social constructions and material social practices produced, shared, negotiated, and trusted by members of a particular group, is precisely such a world (see Rubin, Fein, and Vandenberg 1983). In a similar vein, Lev Vygotsky, the Soviet developmental psychologist, noted that the essence of play was to “move in a field of meaning” through taking on different roles and experimenting with fantasy. Play, he suggested, creates a fantastic arena of learning that he called the “zone of proximal development,” wherein children freely experiment with, abide by, and expand the rules, roles, and meanings that they encounter elsewhere in a more structured and strictured way. These practices—which also include engagements with adults and older children who teach and otherwise assist children in learning new things and reaching other levels of development from their own grounds—are essential to young people’s ways of knowing and producing their material social worlds (Vygotsky 1978).

Play and Mimesis

While Schwartzman, Bateson, Vygotsky, and other theorists of play focus on the importance of its transformative aspects, they do so to understand how these work for children as they develop and are incorporated into a symbolic order. In other words, the interest in play and transformation largely concerns how play engagements transform children by fostering cognitive, moral, physical, and social development. Walter Benjamin takes the transformative aspects of play as his starting point and draws from them a larger political message that infuses and is infused by what he called the mimetic

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faculty. Likewise, as Susan Buck-Morss brilliantly points out, Benjamin's interests in children's cognition turn those of Piaget on their head. If for Piaget, the developmental trajectory of children's lives was such that "childish" thinking was banished in the teleological march toward reason, for Benjamin this thinking was what got drummed out of children in the course of bourgeois education, but lay coiled in socialized adults ready to be sprung as revolutionary consciousness (Buck-Morss 1989; cf. Piaget 1954, 1963, 1975). Benjamin was much more interested in the residues and resurgences of this consciousness than in its erasure as a measure of abstract thought and "development."

Benjamin's notion of the mimetic faculty simultaneously encapsulates what is at the heart of play while pointing to its more transformative implications and possibilities. Quite distinct from mimicry, the mimetic faculty is not simply the ability to both see resemblances and create similarities between things, but the flash of insight made or read off of that process that impels a moment of invention. For Benjamin it is the fugitive and fleeting nature of playing at something that may spark a realization that the original is also made up: not a fiction, but a performance, or more dryly, a social construction, that might also be made different (Benjamin 1978a, 333; cf. Taussig 1993). Michael Taussig, among others, calls attention to the potency of this idea. He begins *Mimesis and Alterity* by pointing out what a stunning insight it was that various aspects of social identity, previously naturalized, were social constructions, and he continues by mourning how little was made of it. Understanding the constructedness of social life, he suggests, should underscore its mutability. It should, he goes on, be the beginning rather than the end of the road, as it so often has been.

Children's play offers a wonderful vehicle for continuing on that road. Children's play is riddled with mimetic activities. Children in Howa, as elsewhere, played at being shopkeepers, farmers, homemakers, parents, consumers, charcoal makers, *muezzin*, and truck drivers. Many times they played at the very activities at which they themselves also worked, but their play almost always worked through those aspects of the activities that were somewhat mysterious or in which children did not figure centrally. They told stories, swapped riddles, called to prayer, sang songs, danced, ran around, cracked jokes, and acted like goofballs, their energy and irreverence vying for maximum expression throughout.

In these everyday practices, the children made and played with their identities, wildly imagining themselves otherwise or just tweaking the details. Play is both a form of coming to consciousness and a way to "become other." In his brilliant writings on play, Lev Vygotsky (1978) notes that even when children play at being themselves or play out their contemporaneous relationships, play provides a vehicle for becoming conscious of those relationships and things that they otherwise enact or engage without thinking. The essences of social relationships and material social practices are distilled and brought to light in the course of play. In playing, children are also able to imagine, enact, and transmogrify "becoming other" with fluidity and grace. Though no player worth his or her salt would conceptualize it in such belabored theoretical terms, what else do the opening gambits "Let's play . . . , "I'll be . . . , " or "Pretend



Figure 22. The fantasy of mobility was shared by many boys in Howa, who dreamed of being drivers or their assistants when they grew up. Most, like Talal, never got further than building toy cars, but these got them pretty far.



Figure 23. (Always) ready for her close-up.

you're . . .," signify, if not a literal toying with "becoming other," with making up an identity? The becoming other of play is an intrinsic aspect of its pleasure (with far more interesting possibilities than identity politics has offered), and is the grist of the mimetic faculty.

For Benjamin, as for Vygotsky, one of the key attributes of children's consciousness—which he celebrated as *mimesis*—was an immediate connection between thought and action (see Buck-Morss 1989; Vygotsky 1978). As Buck-Morss (1989, 264) notes, for Benjamin "perception and active transformation are the two poles of children's cognition," and these are severed in the process of bourgeois socialization. Benjamin saw their reconnection and reinvention as the crux of revolutionary consciousness, theorizing that "the relationship between consciousness and society on a historical level was interspersed with another dimension, the level of childhood development, in which the relationship between consciousness and reality had its own history" (Buck-Morss 1989, 265). This consciousness is there to be retrieved in adults and is always already present among children, and Benjamin was interested in the material social practices through which this consciousness might come to the fore. His astute observations of children were directed to this end, and here Benjamin, like Vygotsky, was struck by the fusion of knowledge and action in children's practices. Benjamin's and Vygotsky's perspectives on play were deeply materialist and emphasized how children learned about things by manipulating them and using them creatively, "releasing," in Buck-Morss's words, "new possibilities of meaning" (264). This engagement with things, especially in play, enabled children to learn about and toy

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with the meanings of things in their social world. For Vygotsky (1978) such engagements showed how consciousness was formed in action. At the same time, as Benjamin emphasized, these engagements offered the possibility of refusing accepted meanings and thus, in a tactile material way, they had revolutionary potential.

This sort of tactility and play with meanings was characteristic of children's activities in Howa. Their play-work traced an interesting and mobile juncture of embodied knowledge, spatial scale, and temporality. For instance, when Sami helped his father build a charcoal mound or Rashid helped his father plant their fields, they simultaneously acquired and used knowledge transacted physically at the scale of adult practice. In the fields and forests, using tools generally designed for adults, the children were relatively small, and this physical relationship to their tools and the space of their actions shaped their knowledge. But when Sami built his play charcoal mound or Rashid modeled and played "fields," they literally created in miniature the entire field of practice and tended it from above. These very different ways of embodying the same realm of knowledge (in one case charcoal production, in the other agriculture) suggest an interesting and peculiar relationship between tactility and mastery, as well as an important suppleness in children's ways of knowing. The children, who neither commanded nor oversaw the sequencing of the operations of charcoal production or cultivation at the scale of adult practice, orchestrated these entirely in their miniature worlds. There was a clear back and forth between the scales of play-work and the kinds of learning, knowing, and mastery that took place in each.

This to and fro traced the productive tension between what Taussig calls "copy and contact." Mimesis, he suggests, involves imitation as well as the sensuous connection between "the body of the perceiver and the perceived." He goes on to suggest that "the nature of their interrelationship remains obscure and fertile ground for wild imagining" (1993, 21). The power of the children's play-work in Howa was not just that they made sense of their everyday lives and produced themselves in them, but also that the play-work provided a means for making these different.

Mostly, though, everyday life was not made that different in the course of the children's work-play. "Habit" held sway (see Taussig 1993, 25).¹¹ Part of the reason it did might be attributed to the very same tethers between work and play that made the possibilities of change so palpable. As this chapter has emphasized, children in Howa played at work that they not only were likely to undertake as adults, but that also composed part of their contemporaneous labor. When they played, much of what they played was interstitial with their work. When they worked, they often played at the same time or carved time for play out of their work time. Whatever the particular balance between the two, much of the embodied knowledge associated with the children's play and work was imbricated with their future work. While these intertwined practices were certainly shot through with a frisson of transformation, the intimate connections between work, play, and learning in the children's lives and possible futures created a kind of "tactile knowing"—"habit"—that may have produced more of a tendency toward stability than toward its undoing. Such are the entrenched contradictions of tactility, as much as of

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mimesis itself. Nevertheless, the arena of children's work-play in Howa and elsewhere remains a fruitful area to look for such ruptures.

Play, for instance, was a way for the children to simultaneously learn about, construct, and find ways to live with their social worlds (see Taussig 1993, xi). To paraphrase Marx, they made up their various identities within particular social conditions that they had not made up, or chosen. If most of the time they were trying on roles that readied them to be subjects of capitalism and participants in available worlds of adult work, it is still important to remember that their acts of play were not about copying as much as invention. And in that invention, and the insights it garners and deploys, was the spark of recognition that things, relations, and selves could be otherwise. Making that so is not child's play, of course, but in drawing out the connections between play and the mimetic faculty, I hope to make clear that play is not immaterial to the task.

Children at play encountered the political-economic and sociocultural changes affecting Howa. Just as these changes entered into the children's play in subtle and startling ways, so, too, did their play enter into these historical transformations and offer the possibility of altering them. Taussig refers to this process, playing with a Benjaminian metaphor, as a "two-way street" between the mimetic faculty and history. To this end, the children of Howa played with capitalism quite literally. Their games embraced and toyed with exchange, money, consumership, new modes of local production, and the expanding fields of everyday life in Howa. At the very least they domesticated capitalism as they outfitted themselves as new subjects of its terms. In traversing this street between mimesis and its historical geographies, the play of children in Howa was particularly interesting for its manifold entanglements with their work. The entanglements at once grounded the play and its mimetic aspects in questions of political-economic relations in quite sobering ways and made the possibilities of the inventive flash of mimesis—the playing at work—that much more powerful.

Nexus of Play and Social Transformation

Benjamin was fascinated with children's play in part because he saw in children an inexhaustible ability to use and transform the debris of society in new and creative ways. This insight paralleled directly his antilinear view of history, which he was interested in entering and engaging in order to make something new of its narratives and material forms. He was particularly compelled by the possibilities of reworking the detritus of industrialization and the things of everyday life to completely other ends, as Susan Buck-Morss's *The Dialectics of Seeing* so insightfully explores. The children in Howa played constantly with its debris; virtually nothing was thrown out that did not have a second life in play. For instance in the game of "store" the children used all "found objects" to stand for the commodities in the store. Like the geodramatic games of "fields" or "house," "store" involved the children in producing miniature worlds within which they enacted landscape-appropriate activities and interactions. While many of



Figure 24. By 1995 vehicle construction was an elaborate affair. Unlike the cruder assemblages of a decade earlier (see Figure 22), the late-model vehicles were carefully crafted by children. Tin-can market trucks, such as the one here, were typical. Making them out of all manner of found objects, children filled the trucks with charcoal scraps and other products in rounds of dramatic play.

these material social practices were familiar to the children as observers of village life or as consumers and errand-runners themselves, their enactment involved the children in stretching their knowledge of local commercial exchange and imagining some of its ins and outs. For a start, the game might more accurately have been called “market” because the children clustered several—sometimes up to a dozen—small shops and restaurants together when they played, a scale and intensity of interchange that far exceeded existing venues in Howa.

A typical game involved boys and girls setting up a number of small shops nestled in the base of a tree, along a houseyard wall, or in some other shaded area. The wares included the standard dry goods available in Howa and some more exotic imports, all represented by such things as vials discarded from the village dispensary, tomato paste tins, can and bottle tops, dirt, wads of mud-clay modeled into such things as bread and other foodstuffs, batteries and battery tops, bottles, goat dung, metal scraps, a telegraph pole insulator, shells, wood bits, packages or scraps of packaging, seeds, and shards of glass. In addition to dry goods shops, the commercial enterprises included several restaurants (this in a village with a single commercial eatery that was opened only part of the year), and a well where water was sold at the tap (represented by a large plastic bottle discarded from the clinic). Apart from the several shopkeepers, the well operator, and the restaurant owners, all of whom traded with one another, there were some nonpropertied customers who frequented all the establishments. The medium of

exchange was “china money” (shards of broken crockery and dishes). In some cases this money had been earned and carried over from earlier games of “fields”; other times it just materialized as another prop. “Store” was an elaborate and intricate game that absorbed the children completely in the production and exchange of a wide range of products. Children “spent” many afternoon hours completely enthralled in the market worlds they created *and* had the wherewithal to engage.

Akin to the games of “fields,” “house,” and “store” or the miniature charcoal mounds constructed by Sami, children also constructed miniature mud houses using the techniques and gestures associated with professional builders in the area. This activity was especially popular among boys during the rainy season, when mud was abundant. Like local builders, they mixed sand in the mud and used wood and grass thatch for roofing; and like children all over the world, they learned about building from watching construction projects wherever and whenever they happened (see Benjamin 1978b). For several weeks there was an extensive building project as yet another extended family demonstrated their upward mobility with the construction of a fired mudbrick wall to replace the old mud-and-dung one around their houseyard. Every time I walked by there were children of all ages watching the work. But children in Howa, unlike children in many other parts of the world, also assisted in building projects. Indeed, several children moved from bystander to assistant as the wall project progressed.

One of these boys was Talal, who also took the opportunity to build a small cooking enclosure for his mother adjacent to their house. He and several other ten-year-old boys who had access to donkeys found work as assistants in the wall project. They dug and transported dirt from about two hundred meters away to be used as mortar in the wall, receiving the equivalent of US\$.25 for each donkey load. Talal was on hand each of the several days that work was available, carting approximately twelve donkey loads a day. He was particularly keen because this work was more lucrative than his normal routine of selling water. Not only was he paid more than twice as much per trip, but with a ready customer, the effort took much less time. Large-scale building efforts, such as this one, not only provided jobs for young boys and demonstrated construction methods to children who participated or watched, but they were also an inspiration to them. No doubt the wall project inspired Talal to build his mother a kitchen enclosure. In his effort, he not only copied the mud-brick construction methods of the specialists working nearby, but he used the bricks discarded by the masons. More useful, perhaps, than other children's miniature houses, Talal's kitchen was no less a product of imaginative and playful practice than theirs were. The intertwined practices of assisting in adult construction projects and using their debris to build their own provided the boys with an arena for imagining themselves in the construction trades.

Girls playing “house” likewise manipulated objects through which they imagined and played with the practices of their future lives. They constructed dolls out of straw or sticks and clothed them in scraps of cloth. They delineated their houses with bricks, stones, or sticks, and outfitted them with found objects that served as props. When, like Rashid's sister, they were lucky enough to have access to a miniature mud house,

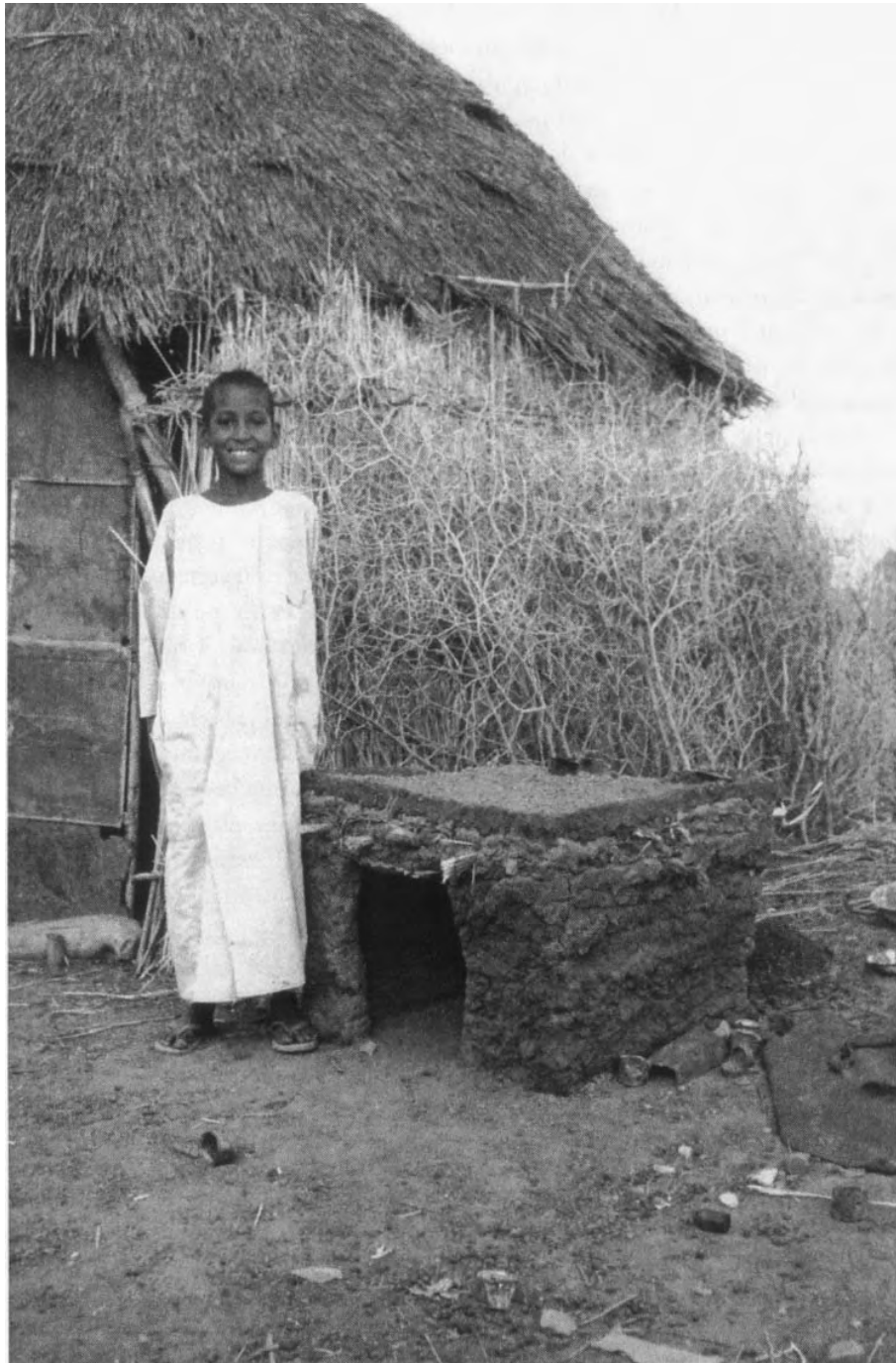


Figure 25. With the rains came clayey mud, and with the mud came opportunity. Never one to miss a chance, Rashid built this house over a couple of days, enlisting a younger friend to help him. They replicated the construction techniques and body language of village builders, and afterward Rashid and his sister played house in their creation.

the girls delighted in playing “house” in and around it. As with the game of “store,” treasures like tin cans, batteries, pieces of metal, bits of straw, packaging, stones, dirt, and water were used to create and populate the play landscape. Although girls playing “house” acted out collecting firewood or fetching water, their focus was largely on the domestic environment and the domain of daily activities, which included child care, food preparation, cooking, cleaning, washing, eating, and visiting, as well as the social events that marked important life passages, such as birth, death, marriage, circumcision, and naming ceremonies. Their playfully elaborate participation in these events and the full range of domestic chores associated with them enabled the girls to experiment with and practice future social roles and to learn about and internalize the domestic activities in which they participated as children, but for which they would be responsible as adults.

The same was true in both versions of the agricultural game, “fields.” These games were elaborate miniature reconstructions of the environments and agricultural practices associated with both irrigated and rain-fed cultivation. As their play attests, the children were well aware of the distinctions between the two. In “tenancies” they built the ridges characteristic of irrigation in the area; planted the cash crops associated with the Suki Project, cotton and groundnuts; used tractors and other tools and equipment associated with mechanized cultivation; and spent a good deal of time and energy weighing and measuring their play harvests, then distributing shards of “china money” differentially according to each “farmer’s” yield. In the dryland version of the game, the children planted the traditional crops of sorghum and sesame, complemented with legumes and vegetables; they did not construct irrigation ditches or ridges in their fields, but sprinkled “rain” on them instead; they built *habiya*, platforms from which children scared away birds; they threshed the sorghum and sesame manually, saving the stalks for fodder; and, with due reference to the considerable socioeconomic changes taking place in their village, they reserved part of their product for household use, exchanging only the surplus along with sesame, the traditional cash crop.

The acuity with which socioeconomic or political-ecologic relations were absorbed in the play was extraordinary. The recognition of the commodity form of cotton and groundnuts, for instance, was witnessed in the formal measurement of yields and the precise (and unequal) payments for them. Sorghum, on the other hand, was not “weighed,” but was trundled to a storehouse and kept for household consumption. The power of money—china or otherwise—worked across games. Compensated farmers exchanged their shards for all manner of goods in the game of “store,” which was played simultaneously or at other times. The children’s mimetic exchanges embodied, and were embodied in, Howa’s lurch toward the monetization of everything.

Along these lines, cars were most popular among the many things that children, particularly boys, modeled or constructed out of mud, clay, metal, or other materials. Literally and metaphorically seen as “tickets to ride,” vehicles were constantly made by boys from objects and debris found in and around the village. The romance of the road, and the money it was seen to bring, were expressed by many boys in Howa in the way

they constructed and played with these vehicles. As the children in Howa rushed toward their own futures, the imagined paths ahead were different for boys and girls. Of course they played at the gendered work roles common to their elders, but beyond that, boys were more likely to experiment with new roles enmeshed in the commodity world outside of Howa, while girls tended to play at the reproductive activities that characterized their mothers' lives. Whereas boys built cars as well as farm implements, girls made and clothed straw dolls for playing "house," outfitting them with traditional tools, including largely obsolete grinding stones, used by then only when the mill was out of commission. Some girls did, however, play "store" and through it entered the commoditized fray that was increasingly central in Howa.

Each of these forms of play individually and collectively illuminate different aspects of the relationship between play and social transformation: how play is transformed, how play marks social transformation, and how play itself can be transformative. For instance, the variations in the games of "fields" suggest the way *play is transformed* in the course of political-economic and social transformation. The children absorbed and reflected the differences between subsistence and tenant cultivation in the different enactments of their agricultural geodramas, placing in sharp relief such things as the cash nexus, land-use patterns, food security, and production cycles. While in this sense "fields" certainly also *marked local social transformations*, the heightened importance of money that characterized Howa during the arc of these children's childhoods seemed most sharply reflected in their games of "store." Here their play suggested a riot of consumption that certainly outstripped that which was then in place in the village. In fact, the children engaged in buying and selling with such gusto that the game seemed to reflect—or call forth—an almost frenzied ascendance of capitalist exchange in their community. This sense was echoed in the course of one of my research strategies. To get at their environmental knowledge I did a "geodramatic" exercise with the children, giving them toy animals, vehicles, and human figures to enact everyday life in the village. In this exercise, I was struck by how frequently the children put one or another of the animals in the truck and took it to market. The level of animal sales in this exercise far exceeded actual levels in the village during that time, although it tragically presaged the famine-drought years on the horizon.

Finally, as suggested by the discussion of mimesis, *play also transforms the people playing* and opens the possibility for more willful social transformations. While this was true across the range of the children's activities, it was particularly clear in both the games of "house" and in the children's construction activities. In both of these arenas the children playing also worked with the materials at hand, and the two realms of activity infused one another. Many of the girls who played "house" also collected firewood and fetched water, for instance, whereas many village women, whom they were playing at being, did not. In their play, the girls enacted their liminal status between being girls and women, as well as the shifts that were slowly becoming apparent in the gendered division of household labor. Their doll selves went to the fields to collect wood while they also tended to household chores, entertained, and engaged in various

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rituals and celebrations in miniature. The boys assisting in village construction projects drew on them to imbue their play-work projects with appropriate gestures and techniques. In each aspect—as assistants and in their independent projects—the boys were likely to have sensed the possibility of, and been experimenting with, a different life from that of farming. In both playing “house” and construction, the children were blending genres and weaving together different practices that might open avenues for changing their and their community’s practices more broadly.

Despite these lively connections between work and play, and the inventive ways children encountered new social forms and made them their own, it remains that, to the extent that the possibilities of the mimetic faculty celebrated by Benjamin and others worked, it worked to help the children embrace and become subjects of capitalism. The possibilities of inventing something else remained only possibilities, rather than actual instances of social transformation in Howa, though of course the locally ascendent capitalism was certainly calling forth new kinds of identities that the children were inventing in their play and otherwise.

Yet this situation was precarious and indeterminant, in part because the larger economy of Sudan mostly undid political-economic relations in Howa, rather than constructing an alternative to draw children’s imaginations and, somewhat paradoxically, in part because the forward motion of capitalism was well entrenched in Howa. It appeared to me that the everyday practices of children in Howa were hurtling toward some kind of undoing in 1981 because of heightened commodification, deteriorations in the local environment, and changed land-tenure relations, among other things. Among the generation of children with whom I worked, there were likely to be significant disjunctures between what they learned as children and what they would need to know as adults, and for those coming up behind them, formal schooling appeared likely to be increasingly important. The increased importance of formal schooling was sure to change the balance of practices that characterized children’s everyday lives. Apart from altering the relation between work and play as everyday practices and fields of meaning, the increasing importance of formal education was likely to modify the kinds of knowledge valued in Howa. This, of course, was the intent of the state in promulgating it.

This struggle over work, play, and schooling was going on during my time in Howa. Children were subjects and objects in this encounter over social production and reproduction and the construction of identities. Their everyday lives, as terrains of the struggle and embodiments of ways of imagining things differently, were a powerful way to understand the process and possibilities of change. But the weight of capitalism and abstractions of knowledge were everywhere.